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KENYATTA UNIVERSITY

INSTITUTE OF OPEN & VIRTUAL LEARNING

DEPARTMENT OF PHILOSOPHY AND RELIGIOUS STUDIES

ARE 271: HISTORY OF ISLAMIC CIVILIZATION & RELIGION

KAHUMBI MAINA

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Course Overview

This course entails a broad survey of the civilization of Islam in its various forms and spheres of activity from the rise of Prophet Muhammad to the present. It also aims at examining how the political philosophy, the Qur'an, social order, intellectual developments and religious movements were shaped by the overall world-view of Islam.

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LECTURE 1:

INTRODUCTION

Lesson 1.1 The Meaning of Islam and the Concept of Din

1.1.1 Introduction

We will begin our series of lectures for this course by defining the terms Islam and Muslims and the concept of Din.

1.1.2 Objectives



By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Define the terms Islam and Muslims
- Explain the Islamic concept of Din

1.1.3 Content



What is the Meaning of Islam?

The Arabic root “SLM” which is pronounced ‘*salm*’. *Salm* implies peace from the Arabic word ‘*aslama*’ that means he/she submitted. It also implies purity, submission and obedience.

Islam is complete submission to the will of Allah and total obedience to His laws. Islam is an all-embracing definition of submission to the will of Allah. It is the religion that brings peace to human kind when one submits and commits himself/herself to the will of Allah.



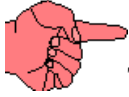
Who is a Muslim?

A Muslim is the one who submits himself/herself to Allah by professing the faith or religion of Islam. A Muslim believes that Islam is the original and universal religion of humankind. It was revealed to humankind through successive prophets.

According to the Qur’an 21:102, Islam is the only true religion of humankind professed by all prophets from Adam to Muhammad (see Qur’an 2:128-140; 42:13). The essence of the message of all prophets of Allah was Islam. A Muslim therefore accepts without discrimination all the prophets of Allah. Allah’s message to humanity ceased coming with the last revelations received by Prophet Muhammad. The message was the Qur’an that Muslims believe is the most comprehensive and final message to humankind. It is the guidance to be followed by all Muslims.

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Note



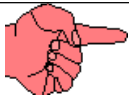
The term “Mohammedanism” as used in reference to Muslims is a misnomer. This reference implies that Muslims worship Muhammad. Islam is not another “ism” like Judaism, Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Zoroastrianism, Shintoism or Marxism etc.



What is Din?

Islam is described as din, which means a complete way of life. It does not separate the sacred and the secular, the Godly and the earthly things. It does not prescribe to the principle of “give unto Caesar what is Caesar’s and to God what is Gods”.

Note



Islam is not a mere creed. Rather it encompasses all aspects of life: economic systems, political and social organizations, codes of conduct and a philosophy of life.

1.1.4 Summary



In this lesson we have looked into the meaning of the words Islam, Muslims and Din. We have seen that Islam means submission and total surrender to the will of Allah and total obedience to His laws. We have defined Muslims as the followers of Islam and Din as complete way of life. Finally, we have noted that Islam is the religion that was professed by all prophets who preceded Muhammad. In the next lesson, we will examine the highlights of the life of Prophet Muhammad.

1.1.5 Key Concepts



Islam: complete submission/surrender to the will of Allah and total obedience to His laws
Muslim: one who professes Islam; a follower of Islam
Din: a complete way of life

1.1.6 Activity



“The terms Mohammedans and Mohammedanism when applied to Muslims and Islam respectively, is misnomers”. Discuss

1.1.7 Further Reading



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Lesson 1.2 Highlights of the Life of Muhammad and the Rise of Islam

1.2.1 Introduction

This lesson examine the main events in the life of Muhammad both in Mecca and Medina, the rise of Islam and the formation of the *umma*

1.2.2 Objectives



- To highlight the main events in the life of Muhammad.
- To explain how the revelation of the Qur'an came about.
- To discuss how Muhammad established the supremacy of Islam in Arabia.

1.2.3 Content

Muhammad was born in Mecca in about 570 (CE). He hailed from the Quraishy tribe one of the many tribes of the Arabs. His father Abdallah died before he was born and his mother Amina died when he was 6 years old. Orphaned at an early age, the boy Muhammad was taken care of by his grandfather Abdul Muttalib and later by his uncle Abu Talib, after the death of the grandfather. At the age of 25 years, he married a wealthy widow called Khadija who was 40 years old.



How did the revelations come about?

Muhammad used to take retreats and worship in solitude at the cave of Hira near Mecca. It was in this place that Muhammad received his first revelation in the year 610. Other revelations followed the first one. God revealed these revelations to Muhammad through the Angel Gabriel. The revelations continued for a period of 23 years until shortly before his death in 632 (CE). These revelations in their entirety constitute the Qur'an, which is sublime and source of Muslim moral conduct.

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What is the language of the Qur'an?

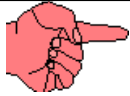
The Qur'an was revealed in Arabic. Arabic hence became an integral part of the revelation. It is the language of the Qur'an. As a bearer of the Qur'an, Muhammad became a prophet. He was not only a prophet but also the seal of the prophethood. His message or dispensation perfects all the preceding ones that are henceforth abrogated due to their falsification by the Jews and Christians. Through Muhammad's prophethood, Allah sent His final revelation (message) to humankind.



What was the essence of Muhammad's message?

Muhammad set out to declare the new message to his people. He taught and preached to them about the oneness of Allah, over drinking, idol worship, the day of judgement, resurrection, etc. He attacked all the social ills that bedevilled his community.

Note



Muhammad's message was a threat to the *statusquo*, so he faced stiff opposition and persecution from the Quraishy.



What was the nature of the opposition and persecutions?

Persecution came in form of insults and all types of epithets were used against Muhammad in order to discredit him. He was regarded as a magician; that jinn possessed him; a soothsayer etc.



Who were among the first converts to Islam?

He only got solace from his wife who was among the early converts to the new faith. Muhammad also gained converts from among the outcasts and under privileged people in society such as slaves and poor people. Among the early converts to Islam, besides Khadija, were Abu Bakr a prominent merchant and Ali his cousin and later son-in-law. His uncle Abu Talib who was his guardian never accepted Islam but he stood firm to defend the new faith. Meanwhile Muhammad got some respite.



What was this respite?

He was taken on a night journey to heaven. He was transported on an animal called al-buraq and then ascended (*mir'aj*) to the seventh heaven. *Mir'aj* was a physical and spiritual journey. The Prophet was shown all that is in heaven and the universe under the light and glory of God. It was during the *mir'aj* that Allah commanded the five daily prayers and fasting for Muslims. The Prophet also met and

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addressed all the previous prophets. The *mir'aj* gave the Prophet hope and courage at the time that there was a lot of persecutions.

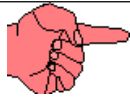


What was Muhammad's response to the persecutions?

When persecutions intensified, Muhammad urged some of his followers to migrate to the Christian Kingdom of Abyssinia to seek refuge there. This was in the year 615 (CE). The King, Negus accorded Muslims refuge. Later on Muhammad attempted to seek refuge in Taif, a town, southeast of Mecca, but that failed. Meanwhile, he secured the support of people of Yathrib through signing the First and Second Pledges of Aqaba.

In 622 (CE), the Prophet migrated from Mecca to Yathrib when he felt his life threatened. This migration is called the *hijra*.

Note



The **Hijra** is a turning point in the history and development of Islam

Hijra marks the dawn of a new (Islamic) era. It is the starting point of an Islamic Calendar that was inaugurated by Caliph Umar (see Lecture 2, Lesson 3). Yathrib, the host town became the City of the Prophet (*al-madinat ul-nabi*) or simply Medina.



What events constituted the Medinan Period?

On arrival in Medina, the Muslims who migrated from Mecca became known as *Muhajirun* (Emigrants) and those who helped (supported) them became the *Ansars* (Helpers/Supporters). The *Muhajirun* and the *Ansar* coalesced to form the first *umma*. The community's bond of and membership was the common faith (Islam) and not blood or kinship ties. In other words, there was no tribal affiliation. All the believers were guardians of one another. They enjoined good and forbid evil and followed all religious sanctions that were required of them. In the new community, Muhammad was the religio-political leader. He combined the various roles of a prophet, head of state, commander of the army, chief judge and lawgiver.

During the period of consolidation of the *umma*, Friday was substituted for Sabbath and the *adhan* (call to prayer) was decreed in place of gongs and trumpets. Ramadhan (the 9th month in the Muslim calendar) was prescribed as month of fasting and the *Qibla* (direction of prayer) was changed from Jerusalem to Mecca. The pilgrimage to the *ka'aba* - the central sanctuary of worship in Mecca – was sanctioned.

From 622 to 632 (CE), the Prophet used military and diplomatic manoeuvres to expand and establish the supremacy and hegemony of Islam over Arabia. In 624, was fought the Battle of Badr between the Muslims and the Meccans (Quraishy). The Muslims, who had only fielded 300 soldiers against over 1000 Meccans, had a decisive military victory. This victory was perceived as a divine sanction of the new faith and a moral and spiritual victory for Islam.

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In 625, the Muslims were defeated at the Battle of Uhud that the Meccans had waged to avenge the defeat of Badr. In this battle, the Prophet was wounded but the Quraishy could not follow their victory because of the enormous casualties that they had. The Muslims and Islam recovered and passed on gradually from the defensive to the offensive

In 627, the Battle of Trenches was fought. The Meccans had mobilized a force of about 20,000 strong men. However, Muslims had a new defensive tactic. They dug a trench round the unprotected parts of the city of Medina to keep off the attacks from the enemies. Eventually, the disgruntled and disgusted besiegers withdrew at the end of the month with a casualty of 25 men on both sides.

In 628, the Prophet and the Muslims signed the treaty of Hudaibiyya with the Meccans. According to this treaty, the Meccans and the Muslims were to be treated on equal terms. The Meccans however breached the terms of the treaty and in January 630 (CE) the Prophet marched to Mecca as a conqueror. There was no resistance on the Meccans. This triumphal entry completed the conquest of Mecca. The Prophet smashed all the 360 idol gods of the Meccans. He displayed leniency in his treatment of the enemies whom he offered a general amnesty.

In 631, the Muslims waged the expedition of Tabouk, consequently securing treaties of peace with Christians and Jewish tribes. These people sought the protection of the Muslims and in return they promised to pay *jizya* (a poll/protection tax).

Accompanied by 14,000 Muslims, the prophet made a farewell pilgrimage to Mecca on 23 February 632 (CE). He gave his farewell speech at Mount Arafat, in which he stressed on the unity of Allah, the day of judgement, the sacredness of life, respect for the prophets, women and slaves. He also stressed the importance of Muslim brotherhood among other things. The prophet died three months later after the farewell pilgrimage on June 8th 632.

1.2.4 Summary



In this lesson, we have examined the milestones in the life of Muhammad both in Mecca and Medina. It is demonstrated that when Muhammad declared his message, he received opposition and persecution from his people. Consequently, he devised various survival strategies. It is shown that at Medina, Muhammad was a prophet and a statesman. Through a series of battles and military manoeuvres, he was able to establish the supremacy of Islam in Arabia.

1.2.5 Key Words



Ansar: Helpers/Supporters

Hijra: migration or withdrawal, particularly that of Prophet Muhammad from Mecca to Medina in 622

Mira'j: the night journey

Muhajirun: Emigrants

Umma: Muslim community

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1.2.5 Activities



- Examine the life of Muhammad both in Mecca and Medina demonstrating how he was a prophet and statesman
- The hijra was a turning point in the history of Islam. Discuss this statement in view of the events in the post-hijra Islamic dispensation.

1.2.6 Further Reading



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LECTURE 2: THE PERIOD OF THE FOUR ORTHODOX CALIPHS (632-661 CE)

Lesson 2.1 The Issue of the Caliphate

2.1.1 Introduction

Generally, the caliphate period in the history of Islam stresses from 632 – 1258 CE. It comprises three phases. These are:

- The period of the four Orthodox caliphs or the rightly guided caliphs (632-661)
- The Umayyad dynasty (661-750 CE)
- The Abbasid dynasty (750-1258 CE)

The period of the caliphate led to the formation and development of Islamic ideology and the different Muslim institutions. It is a period that witnessed Islam consolidating its hold on Arabia and later expanding far and wide through campaigns of conquest.

In this lesson, I will examine the period of the four orthodox caliphs. The other two, i.e. Umayyad and Abbasid dynasties will be examined later (see Lectures 4 and 5). But first of all, let us discuss the major event in the history of Islam that ushered in, the period of the four orthodox caliphs.

2.1.2 Objectives



- To discuss how the Muslim community solved the contentious issue of the caliphate following the death of the Prophet.
- To identify the various groups that staked their claim to the caliphate.

2.1.3 Content

The Prophet died in 632 (CE) leaving no successor. He was survived by only one daughter Fatimah the wife of Ali, and the mother of Hasan and Hussein. The Prophet had not designated a successor. Therefore, the first issue that the umma had to contend with was that of the caliphate (*khilafat* – succession). Various groups arose and claimed their right to the caliphate.



Which were these groups and what grounds did they advance for their claim?

Muhajirun [Emigrants]

This was the first group to stake its claim to the caliphate. They argued that they belonged to the family of the Prophet. That they were the first converts to Islam. Hence being the first to acknowledge the prophethood of Muhammad and to bear the brunt of tribulations, persecutions and enmity at a time when the future of Islam was very bleak indeed

The Ansar (Helpers/Supporters)

This was the second group to lay their claim to the caliphate. Their grounds were that they defended the Prophet and Islam when he had been rejected and faced stiff opposition from his own people. They also argued that they assisted the Prophet and Muslims in fighting their enemies until the supremacy of Islam was established in Arabia.

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The Legitimists

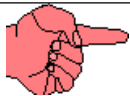
This was the third group whose claim to the caliphate was based on the argument that Allah and Muhammad could not have left the Muslim community without a designated person to succeed the Prophet. This group argued that Ali, the paternal cousin and son-in-law of the Prophet, and one among the first two or three converts to Islam, was the one designated and only legitimate successor to the Prophet.

The Umayyads

This was the fourth group to stake their claim to the caliphate. The Umayyads formed the Quraishy aristocracy. They were among the educated, wealthy, powerful and influential people during the pre-Islamic days. Unfortunately, this group vehemently opposed Islam and in fact the Umayyads were among the last to embrace Islam. However due to their former social status, the Umayyads laid their claim to the caliphate.

The first group triumphed with the appointment of Abu Bakr, the father in-law of the Prophet as the first caliph. He was a close confidant of the Prophet and one of the earliest converts to Islam. He had also been appointed by the Prophet to lead Friday communal prayers in his absence. Abu Bakr thus became the first caliph in Islam taking the title successor or caliph of the Prophet of God. He was therefore the first in a line of successors called *Khulfa-ur-Rashideen* (the rightly guided caliphs) that included Umar, Uthman and Ali. The first three caliphs lived in Medina except Ali who established his headquarters in Kufah.

Note



The four orthodox caliphs were close associates and relatives of the Prophet.

2.1.5 Summary



In this lesson we have established how the Muslim community solved the contentious issue of the caliphate following the death of the Prophet. It is shown that various groups staked their claims to the caliphate. Eventually, it is the Muhajirun who triumphed with the appointment of Abu Bakr as the first caliph

2.1.6 Key Words



caliph (khalifa): successor to Muhammad as a leader of community
khilafat [caliphate]: succession
khulafa-ur-rashdeen: the four rightly guided caliphs

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2.1.7 Activities



- Discuss how the Muslim community solved the contentious issue of the caliphate following the death of the Prophet in 632 (CE)
- In your opinion, what do you think were the reasons for the appointment of Abu Bakr as the caliph?

2.1.8 Further Reading



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Lesson 2.2 The Reign of Abu Bakr (632-634 CE)

2.2.1 Introduction

Having looked at the Muslim community solved the contentious issue of the caliphate and the appointment of Abu Bakr as the first caliph, this lesson examine the reign of Abu Bakr. Specifically, we will attempt to show how Abu Bakr consolidated the Muslim empire after the upheavals that followed the death of the Prophet

2.2.2 Objectives



- To discuss how Abu Bakr consolidated the Muslim empire following the death of the Prophet.
- To assess the achievements under the caliphate of Abu Bakr.

2.2.3 Content

Abu Bakr was born 50 years before the *hijra* (572 CE). Before conversion to Islam, he had led a chaste life. He was a rich trader and this made him influential in the social circles of Mecca. He was among the first people to accept Islam. He used a lot of his wealth to emancipate Muslim slaves. His influence was instrumental in the conversion to Islam of many important Quraish personalities. He was a constant companion and confidant of the Prophet who conferred on him the title *Siddiq* [the veracious] for his power to discern truth.

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He was a father in law of the Prophet through his daughter Ayesha, who married the Prophet. Abu Bakr led an austere life that was marked by simplicity and frugality. He was a resolute and firm in his decisions, a quality manifested in fighting apostasy and the rebellious tribes. A very pious man, he fasted during the day and spent whole nights in prayers and meditation. He was an orator and a poet and an authority on genealogy.

As a caliph, Abu Bakr was the political and military leader of the *umma*. He was also the religious head of the community, a factor manifested in his role in leading the *Jumu'ah* (Friday) prayers.



How did the death of the Prophet Muhammad threaten the well being of the Muslim community?

Most of the nomadic tribes who feared being subordinated to the people of Medina refused allegiance to Abu Bakr. These people did not have any say in the appointment of the caliph. They repudiated their loyalty to Islam. The repudiation of these tribes of Islam and their attempts to secede from the Islamic fold is referred to as *ridda* or apostasy. Some of these tribes had not formally adopted Islam but they had submitted to the Muslims through the payment of *jizya*. The death of the Prophet gave these people an opportunity to repudiate the payment of *jizya*. Moreover, these people had become loyal to the teachings of rival false prophets who had appeared in the scene.



Who are some of these prophets?

Among these false prophets was one called Musailima who had gathered a lot of support among the tribe of Banu Hanifa of central Arabia.



How did Abu Bakr deal with the threat of the false prophets?

Abu Bakr directed his efforts to the reclamation of the apostates and the extermination of the false prophets. He gathered all the loyal chiefs and divided them into 11 independent columns each under the commander of a distinguished leader; each was entrusted with the subjugation of a particular region. Khalid bin Walid the brilliant general whom the Prophet had dubbed the “sword of Allah” was given the command of the expedition against Musailima and the Banu Hanifa.

The caliph’s envoys were sent to all provinces and rebellious tribes to repent and submit themselves for readmission into the Islamic fold. Those who submitted were treated with leniency and considered as reconciled brothers of Islam. The Banu Hanifa and their false prophet Musailima were defeated and brought to submission by Muslim forces.

The west coast of Persian Gulf whose people had rebelled after the death of the Prophet also submitted. Abu Bakr therefore consolidated Arabia in a series of campaigns that crushed the tribal revolts. Thus, he preserved the solidarity and unity of Islamic state. The momentum acquired in these internal campaigns

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transformed Arabia into an armed camp that had to seek new outlets and the organized warfare and techniques had to be used elsewhere.

At the conclusion of *riddah* wars, Abu Bakr issued summons to a holy war. He urged those who volunteered not to harm women, children and old people and to refrain from pillage, destruction of crops, fruit trees, flock and herds and not to kill Christian monks and anchorites (hermits or recluses). The army was divided into three detachments of about 3000 people. Each was led respectively by Amr bin al-Aas – the future conqueror general of Egypt – Yazid ibn Abu Sufyan, Surahbil ibn Hasanah and Khalid bin Walid. The first two generals marched northwards and began operations in southern and southeastern Syria. Khalid's force raided Iraq where it routed a small Persian detachment and this led to the submission of the Arab Christians of that area. Under the wise leadership of Khalid, Muslim's conquests were pushed to the frontiers of the Persian Empire. In the "Battle of Chains", the Persians were thoroughly routed. This was followed by the defeat of the Syrian troops. The fall of Ajnadayn on July 634 laid open the whole of Palestine to the Muslims. Damascus, the later capital of the Umayyads, fell in September 634 (CE). This led to the defeat of the Byzantines.

Abu Bakr's caliphate lasted for 2 years and 3 months. He died of illness on 23rd August 634 CE (22 AH). Before his death he appointed Umar bin Khattab as his successor. Prior to this, Umar had been the Supreme Judge in civil cases and had led public prayers in Abu Bakr's absence.



What were the achievements of Abu Bakr?

The following were the main achievements of Abu Bakr.

- He put down anarchy and rebellion and brought order to a land where commotion and insecurity reigned supreme after the death of the Prophet.
- He brought back to the Islamic fold the apostates and the wavering or unsteady new converts.
- He eliminated the false prophets and pretenders who had instigated apostasy and rebellion or made them to see the futility of their apostasy and rebellion.
- He fused into one nation the tribal principalities and mutually hostile clans.
- He challenged the Persian and Roman empires by engaging them in unequal battles and defeated them. This paved the way for the expansion of Islam.
- He ordered the compilation of the Qur'an by appointing Zaid bin Thabit the Prophet's scribe to record the Qur'an in one volume. This had been necessitated by the death of the companions - who had committed the Qur'an to memory – during the expeditions against apostates and rebellious tribes. The Qur'an had hitherto been recorded in separate pieces of different writing materials such as palm bark, leather, bones, stones and rough paper. Umar felt the necessity of collecting the Qur'an text and persuaded Abu Bakr to take up that task otherwise there was danger of parts of the Qur'an being lost.

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2.2.4 Summary



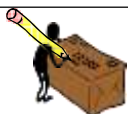
In this lesson we have discussed the reign of Abu Bakr, the first Orthodox caliph. We have highlighted some of the qualities that stood him in good stead in his role as a religious, military and political leader of the *umma*. Largely, Abu Bakr expanded and consolidated the Muslim empire. Indeed, he saved Islam from disintegration by putting it on the road to recovery after the upheavals occasioned by the death of the Prophet. The suppression of apostasy, the unification of Arabia and the conquests of Iraq and Syria are evidences of his notable achievements.

2.2.5 Key Word



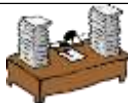
riddah: apostasy [turning away from one's religion].

2.2.6 Activities



- Identify and discuss the main challenges that faced Caliph Abu Bakr when he ascended the throne in 632 (CE).
- Discuss the achievements of the reign of Abu Bakr.

2.2.6 Further Reading



Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**, pp.96-105
Hitti, P.K. 1973. **The History of the Arabs**. London: Macmillan, pp.51-179
Hussain, S.A. 1977. **The Glorious Caliphate**, pp.9-46
Lewis, B. (ed.) 1987. **Islam from the Prophet Muhammad to the Capture of Constantinople**, in 2 volumes. Vol. 1, p. 5

Lesson 2.3 The Reign of Umar (634-644 CE).

2.3.1 Introduction

In our previous lesson we looked at the reign of Abu Bakr, the first orthodox caliph. In this lesson we are going to examine the reign of Umar, the second orthodox caliph.

2.3.2 Objectives



- To examine the reign of Caliph Umar.
- To assess the main achievements of his reign.

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2.3.3 Content

Umar was the second caliph and he took over the reins of the caliphate after the death of Abu Bakr. Umar was one of the Prophet's most trusted companions. He was related to the Prophet through his daughter Hafsa, who married the Prophet. Umar was a person of simplicity and devotion to duty. He led an austere life and endowed with the arts of eloquence, oratory, poetry, valour (bravery) and intrepidity (fearlessness).

In his judgements and opinions, he displayed soundness of mind and sagacity such that some of his opinions became religious tenets.



Which are some of those opinions that became religious tenets?

- He was the one who suggested that a loud resonant (resounding) voice of the *muadhin* (caller to prayer) should proclaim the greatness of Allah and invite people to their salvation.
- His suggestion about the disposal of the prisoners of Battle of Badr
- Observation of *purdah* (veiling) by Muslim ladies
- Abstention from saying death prayers of a *munaḥiqun* (hypocrite), Abdallah bin Obey.

All these suggestions and opinions found approval through Qur'anic revelations. Equally, it was on Umar's insistence and advice that Abu Bakr ordered the compilation of the Qur'an.

After he ascended the throne, Umar quelled a rebellion that had broken out in Iraq. Under him Muslim expeditions were conducted into the Persian Empire with many victories being realised. The Battle of Cadesiya in 636 CE led to the Muslim conquests of an entirely large Persian army that greatly outnumbered four times the Muslim force. This battle assisted Muslims to acquire a lot of booty consisting of jewels and other precious gifts.

During Umar's reign, the siege of Damascus that had started during the reign of Abu Bakr was completed in 635 CE. Khalid bin Walid made a treaty with the residents of Damascus when he gained entry into the city. In this treaty, Khalid assured the residents of the safety of their lives and goods and their churches. No houses were to be pulled down or taken away from their owners; no spoils were taken and no one was taken captive as long as they agreed to pay tribute (*jizya*).

The siege of Damascus was followed by the Battle of Fahl (636 CE), in which the Roman forces were defeated. The Romans were given the option of accepting Islam or payment of tribute. This was conquest was followed by others in Jordan in which the inhabitants were either defeated or surrendered. They were given terms of capitulation whereby they were given full protection together with their property, land and places of worship. Some of the land was taken for the construction of mosque.

The defeat of Romans in the Battle of Yarmuk (637 CE) sealed the fate of Syria. This was followed by conquests in Aleppo under the command of Abu Obaidah. Many of the tribes accepted either Islam or to pay tribute. Abu Obaidah laid a siege on Antioch – capital of North Syria –, which capitulated. This led to the fall of the whole of Northern Syria from Damascus to Asia Minor. Arab tribes settled in this area. The Christians either retired unmolested into the Roman territory or agreed to pay tribute.

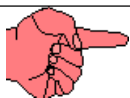
The whole of Palestine was conquered and the Patriarch of Jerusalem appealed for peace after the commander of the Roman army escaped to Egypt. The terms of surrender were made between Caliph Umar and the Patriarch. An easy tribute was to be paid by the inhabitants who were to keep their shrines and

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churches. After this conquest the one of Mesopotamia followed in 638 CE. In 643 CE, the remnants of the Persian stronghold were defeated and with it, the whole of Persian Empire came under the Muslim supremacy. Gradually, the Persians adopted Islam; opposition to Islam and Muslims ceased altogether and the Islamic state extended from the Caspian Sea to the Indian Ocean.

Caliph Umar appointed Muawiyya, son of Abu Sufyan the governor of Syria. This later turned out to be the foundation of the Umayyad dynasty. The conquest of Egypt took place in 641 CE. The commander of the Muslim forces was Amr bin al-Aas who routed the Byzantine forces. This conquest brought to an end the reign of Christ and Caesar. The Copts did not regret the departure of their persecutors. The Muslims who were welcomed by the Copts as their liberators selected Memphis as their headquarters. Around this headquarters grew a military station called Fustat (Encampment) that developed into the capital city of Egypt, the modern Cairo. Amr bin al-Aas built a famous mosque that is still known by his name. Along the North African coast, Amr eliminated the Roman settlements and thus extended the domain of Islam towards the west.

Note



The Muslim conquest of Egypt led to the spread of Islam to the rest of North Africa.

The decade of Umar's reign (634-644 CE) was the most glorious in the annals of the Arab Muslims. Indeed, Umar's name according to Muslim tradition is the greatest in early Islam after that of the Prophet Muhammad. Umar has been treated as the personification of all the virtues a caliph ought to possess.



What were the achievements of the reign of Caliph Umar?

- Umar presided over the conquest of large portions of the then known world. In the east, he liquidated the Persian Empire. In Syria, Jordan and Palestine, the Muslims were in firm control and set up stable governments.
- He undertook administrative measures and reforms of lasting benefit. He organized all Muslims into a complete religio-military commonwealth
- He enlarged the square round the *ka'ba* by pulling down buildings located too close to it after compensating the owners.
- He renovated the boundary pillars of the *haram* and the sacred territory and built halting stations on the pilgrim route to Medina.
- He established the department of finance
- He introduced the Islamic era commencing from the new moon of the first month of Muharram in the year of the Prophet's migration to Medina. Hence he fixed the *hijra* as the commencement of the Muslim era.

A Persian slave called Abu Lulu (Feroze) assassinated Umar. He died on 26th of *Dhul Hijjah*, 23 AH. (644 CE). Umar was buried by the side of the Prophet.

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2.3.4 Summary



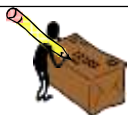
This lesson has examined the reign of the Umar, the second orthodox caliph. Notably there are many achievements that are attributed to his reign. It is not therefore a wonder that the decade of Umar's reign is considered the most glorious in the annals of the Arab Muslims. He was an embodiment of integrity, piety, justice and other virtues. He introduced reforms of far reaching significant contributions to Islam and Muslim community.

2.3.5 Key Words



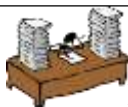
Copts: Native Egyptian Christians
Dhul Hijjah: 12th month in the Muslim Calendar
Muharram: the first month in the Muslim Lunar calendar

2.3.6 Activities



- “Umar's name according to Muslim tradition is the greatest in early Islam after that of the Prophet”. Comment
- Analyse the trends in the expansion of the Muslim Empire during the reign of Caliph Umar.

2.3.7 Further Reading



Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**, pp.106-114
Hitti, P.K. 1973. **The History of the Arabs**, pp.51-179
Hussain, S.A. 1977. **The Glorious Caliphate**, pp.47-91
Lewis, B. (ed.) 1987. **Islam from the Prophet Muhammad to the Capture of Constantinople** pp. 5-20
Saunders, J.J. 1965. **A History of Medieval Islam**. London, pp.45-53

Lesson 2.4 The Reign of Caliph Uthman (644-656 CE)

2.4.1 Introduction

In our previous lesson, we examined the reign of Caliph Umar. Before his death, Umar appointed an electoral body composed of respected companions of the Prophet to nominate a successor. These companions were Abdul Rahman, Uthman, Talha, Zubair, Sa'ad and Ali. They appointed Uthman as the caliph. This lesson examines the reign of Caliph Uthman. It has also analysed the events that culminated into his death in 656 (CE).

2.4.2 Objectives



- To examine the reign and achievements of Caliph Uthman.
- To analyse and assess the factors that led to the death of Uthman.

2.4.3 Content

Uthman was born 47 years before the hijra. He was one of the earliest converts to Islam. He was a distant relative of the Prophet through his maternal grandmother, Bai'da who was a daughter of Abdul Muttalib, and a sister of Abdullah – the Prophet's father. Uthman also married two daughters of the Prophet – Ruqaiyya and later after her death, Umm Kulthoom.

Uthman lived a life of piety and uprightness; he devoted a lot of time to fasting and prayers. He had committed the entire Qur'an to memory; he was one of the scribes of the Prophet and at times recorded the revelations on the dictation of the Prophet.

The death of Umar created an opportunity for some conquered areas to repudiate the payment of *jizya*. There were also revolts in Alexandria and Azerbaijan that Uthman promptly put down. Muawiyya the governor of Syria repulsed the Byzantine attacks in Syria. Meanwhile, Uthman's kinsman Abdulla bin Sa'ad bin Abi Sarh who previously served as officer in charge of tax collections replaced Amr bin al-Aas as the governor of Egypt. Abi Sarh's control over Egypt made him to have an opportunity to extend the Muslim conquests into Tripoli and Carthage with subsequent annexation of these areas. Further annexations were made in Algeria and Morocco.

The first naval fleet was undertaken by Muawiyya to guard against the Byzantine naval attacks and to carry the holy wars into the heartland of the enemy. This fleet advanced on Cyprus and the island was easily overtaken and a large number of men were taken as captives. Attempts by the Byzantines to avenge that defeat three years later were futile.

The caliphate of Uthman lasted for almost 12 years. He was popular within the first six years when the empire duly expanded. Later discontents began to appear. Discontents were directed to the governors of the various provinces. For example Kufah and Basra were hot beds of intrigues. These cities were highly charged with sentiments of disloyalty and rebellion and the unwise change of governors aggravated the situation. In Kufah, the governor Sa'ad was removed and replaced with Mughira who did not meet the expectations. Uthman reinstated Sa'ad who was recalled within a year of reinstatement. He was replaced with Sa'id al-Aas, Uthman's kinsman. This replacement was opposed as it demonstrated the Quraishy's authority and monopoly.

In Basra, the governor Abu Musa was fired and replaced with Abdullah bin Amir. These replacements did not satisfy the peoples' needs but rather eroded the foundations of the Islamic Empire from within. This is because the main cause of the discontents was not the injustice of the governors or their failure to fulfil the demands of the people. Rather the Arab tribes were conscious of their power and the role they had played in the expansion of the empire. As such these tribes were becoming restless and impatient and impatient of the control of the Quraishy. These tribes were developing a spirit of opposition to all authority. Replacement of Amr bin al-Aas by Abi Sarh as governor of Egypt, in spite of the latter's

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brilliant victories, were labelled as an act of nepotism by the Caliph. This created tension and factions in Egypt. Nevertheless, accusations against the caliphate of Uthman were galore.



What were other causes of discontents against Uthman?

- He was accused of making some changes in the routine of the annual pilgrimage by offering full prayers at the Mina. The Prophet and the first two caliphs had offered shortened prayers that are permissible during a journey. Uthman justified his actions by arguing that he conducted full prayers so that the local people upon whom it was incumbent to perform full prayers might not consider shortened prayers to be the rule.
- The detractors of Uthman accused him of pitching tents at Mina for a shelter that had not been done before. He had done so to protect people from scorching sun.
- Uthman included horses in the list of animals that are to paid *zakat* for. This was not the case in the time of the Prophet and the first two caliphs. The shortage of horses then could explain why they were not included.
- He was accused of using *sadaqa* and *zakat* to prosecute war and certain other welfare projects. His detractors accused him of contravening the teachings of the Qur'an regarding the *sadaqa* and *zakat*. Uthman had taken *sadaqa* and *zakat* as loans from the state treasury only to conduct various expeditions as large-scale warfare had necessitated heavy expenditure in equipping the armies and the naval forces.
- The Prophet had reserved a pasture ground at Naqih for grazing of the state's horses and camels. Uthman added two more due to the increase of the state's horses and camels.
- The enlargement of the ground square of the ka'ba and the great mosque at Medina was criticized. The enlargement of the ground square was started by Caliph Umar and carried on by Uthman. The owners of the houses demolished refused compensation and raised a great outcry. He was criticized of using of state's resources to enlarge the Great Mosque, so he used his finances instead.
- His uncle, Hakam bin al-Aas used to maltreat his neighbours and to mock the Prophet. He was exiled from Medina. On several occasions, he pleaded with the Prophet to have his uncle back but the Prophet promised to consider the matter. The issue was still pending by the time of the Prophet's death. The first two caliphs did not allow Hakam back to Medina but on ascending the caliphate Uthman allowed his uncle back to Medina on the basis that the Prophet was ultimately inclined to grant permission.
- There were discontents after Uthman gave 1/5 share of the state's share of the spoils of African war to Abi Sarh. He was rewarding him for his gallantry but with the opposition to his actions, Uthman got the reward refunded.
- He was accused of partisanship, generosity towards his relatives and nepotism. For example, he was accused of allowing his nephew Marwan to purchase the state's share of spoils of war for an inadequate price.
- He was accused of ill-treating and banishment of Abu Zarr Ghifary, a companion of the Prophet and an ascetic who strongly condemned the growing wealth and luxury of the ruling class.
- In his attempts to provide an authoritative and definitive text of the Qur'an to curb against different recitations, Uthman was accused of rescinding (annulling or repealing) the Qur'an. This was a sensible measure that was twisted into an accusation of tampering with the holy book and hence a sacrilege.

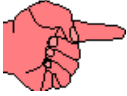
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What were the main events that culminated into the fall of Caliph Uthman?

With all these accusations levelled against Uthman, he reacted by some timid concessions. However disaffection in the garrison camps broke out into an open mutiny. The hatred of tribal warriors angered by the restraints of an un-accustomed discipline was concentrated on representatives of Meccan aristocracy whom Uthman appointed to govern them.

Note



Uthman's policies antagonized the majority of the Emigrants, Helpers and others. He got support from his kinsmen of Syria.

The unrest against Uthman started in Kufa where the governor Walid bin Uqba was accused of debauchery. This unrest spread to Basra, Egypt and Medina. The Arab tribes were displeased with the Quraish and the Quraishites themselves were jealous of the Umayyads (Uthman's clan) and the caliph's favourites. In Medina, two companions of the Prophet, Talha and Zubair (a son-in-law of Abu Bakr) with the backing from Ayesha intrigued against the Caliph and this undermined his position. Attempts by Muawiyya to have his cousin move to Syria where he could have been offered protection by the loyal army was futile. The Caliph vowed, "never to move away from the land where the Prophet had lived and the city where his body was buried".

In 656, bands of mutineers from Egypt, Kufah and Basra appeared in Medina and demanded a reform of the government. Accommodation was apparently to be reached but then failed when the mutineers (rebels) claimed to have intercepted a letter from the Caliph to his governor in Fustat (Egypt) ordering him to kill the ring leaders of the mutiny and to imprison and torture others upon their return from Medina. The rebels insisted that the seal on the letter was that of the Caliph who denied any knowledge of the document, its authority and the author. Consequently, the rebels demanded the abdication of the Caliph but he refused. The rebels besieged him in his house and called for his resignation or death. Meanwhile Muawiyya set off to rescue his relative on hearing about the tumults in Medina. Before the arrival of the Syrian army, the rebels broke into Uthman's house where they found him seated in the inner chamber reading the Qur'an. His wife tried to shield him and several of her fingers were chopped off. The regicides thrust their swords into his body and the blood of the third Caliph flowed over the pages of the Qur'an. He was buried on the third day on a common field during the night. According to Saunders (1965), in this field, "was buried the peace and unity of Islam".



What is the validity of this statement?

This situation is attested to by events following the death of Uthman. Indeed his death was one of the most fateful events in the history of Islam. The secret of the empire was revealed in that, the caliphate was no longer a sacred office but a prize to be snatched through violence. The swords of Muslims hitherto used on non-Muslims were turned against each other as Muslims spilt the blood of Muslims.



What were the achievements of Uthman?

- Uthman consolidated the conquests made during the caliphate of Umar, and also extended the Islamic domain to wider horizons. In the west, Muslim armies conquered and annexed Tripoli and Morocco and Algeria. They equally subjugated the remnants of the Persian Empire, Afghanistan, Khurasan, Turkistan, which were incorporated to the widespread Muslim Empire. These conquests incorporated Armenia and Azerbaijan.
- Uthman issued an authoritative text of the Qur'an that is still in use today.

2.4.4 Summary



This lesson has examined the reign of Caliph Uthman. It is instructive that the reign was peaceful within the first half, but discontents started within the second half. These discontents brought about an atmosphere of unrest that eventually led to the death of Uthman. Evidently, discontents against the Caliph seemed to have overshadowed all his achievements. Due to the various accusations against him, Uthman is a controversial figure in the history of Islam. Some scholars, e.g. Tabari dismiss out rightly the accusations against Uthman, while Ameer Ali, argues that though virtuous and honest, Uthman was feeble in character and quite unequal to the task of government. Notwithstanding scholar's position, the death of Uthman was a tragic event in the history of Islam, in view of the events that took place after his death.

2.4.5 Activities



- “The field in which Uthman was buried was also buried the peace and unity of Islam”. Discuss this statement in view of the events that followed the death of Uthman.
- Show how the weaknesses of the caliphate of Uthman eventually contributed to his death.

2.4.6 Further Reading



Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**, pp.115-125
Hitti, P.K. 1973. **The History of the Arabs**, pp.51-179
Hussain, S.A. 1977. **The Glorious Caliphate**, pp.93-135
Saunders, J.J. 1965. **A History of Medieval Islam**, pp. 45-53

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Lesson 2.5 The Reign of Ali (656-661 CE) and the Outbreak of the Civil War

2.5.1 Introduction

After the death of Uthman, Ali was the leading figure among the companions of the Prophet. He was elected the caliph on June 24th 656 and his election was generally recognized by majority of the Muslims. It is notable that Ali took over the caliphate during a volatile situation occasioned by the death of Uthman. In this lesson, we will demonstrate how political intrigues and the efforts of Ali to consolidate power led to the first civil war in Islam.

2.5.2 Objectives



- To examine the rise of Ali to the caliphate and his efforts to consolidate power after the upheavals occasioned by the death of Uthman.
- To discuss the factors that led to the first civil war in Islam and its consequences.

2.5.3 Content

Ali was the son of Abu Talib, the uncle of the Prophet. He was born around 600 CE, thus was the prophet's junior by about 30 years. He was the first cousin of the Prophet, the husband of his favourite daughter Fatima, the father of his only two surviving male descendants, Hasan and Hussein. Ali was a close associate of the Prophet and among the first believers and converts to Islam. He actively participated in the battles of the Prophet. He lived an austere and simple life and was known for his valour and intrepidity, qualities that were exemplified in the battles that he participated in. He was greatly learned and the Prophet used to refer to him as the "gate of learning. Ali could know when, where and in what circumstance every verse of the Qur'an was revealed. Hence, he is regarded as one of the leading exegetes (interpreters) of the Qur'an. As a constant companion of the Prophet for over 30 years, he was an authoritative interpreter of the Qur'an and the traditions. He was a remarkable orator. As a pious man, he was particular about the daily prayers and the supererogatory prayers. He could spend whole nights in prayer.



How was the political situation when Ali ascended the throne?

Ali came to power at a time when the death of Uthman threatened to tear the Muslim community apart as anarchy reigned supreme. The regicides held control of Medina and on sixth day, they agreed to depart on condition that a caliph was elected. Ali was elected as the caliph and the insurgents retired to their respective countries.

When he ascended the throne, Ali had to contend with his rivals. Talha and Zubair two notable companions of the Prophet gave allegiance to Ali but they later deserted him. The two teamed with Ayesha whom they were related to her. Zubair was her nephew and Talha was her brother in law. The three formed a triumvirate and joined the ranks of the insurgents against Ali at Basra who were calling for vengeance on Uthman's death. They wanted the law of retaliation (*lex talionis*) to be applied to the regicides (killers) of Uthman. A rebellion thus was in the offing and to pre-empt it, Ali dismissed the provincial governors and put his own appointees to replace them. This action added to Ali his list of enemies. Meanwhile the Umayyad family also called for vengeance on Uthman's murders. Muawiyya the governor of Syria spearheaded this call and refused to recognize the legitimacy of Ali's caliphate until such a time that Ali

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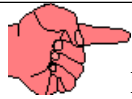
punished the murderers of Uthman in accordance with the Qur'an. Under these circumstances, major revolts broke in the leading cities, which Ali decided to bring to submission. These revolts culminated in the first civil war (*al-fitna*) and the Battle of the Camel on 4th December 656.



Why was the battle so called?

The battle was so named after the camel on which Ayesha rode that was the rallying point for the rebel warriors. On December 9th 656, Ali defeated the coalition forces. Talha and Zubair were killed. Ayesha was captured and treated honourably. She was sent back to Medina where she retired never to engage in any future affairs of the state. After this battle, Ali made his permanent capital at Kufa and inaugurated his rule.

Note



Medina was the capital of the Muslim state during the time of the Prophet and the first three caliphs. Ali's decision to shift the capital to Kufa was a break with the past and marked the end of an era. He opted for Kufa because that was where he had a strong following that supported him.



How did the Battle of Siffin come about?

After the defeat of the opposition forces at the Battle of Camel, Muawiyya agreed to pay allegiance to Ali on condition that he punished the regicides accordingly. Having gathered a lot of support of many tribes and companions dissatisfied with Ali's caliphate, Muawiyya felt confident enough not to submit to Ali. Among his supporters were Amr bin al-Aas the former governor and conqueror of Egypt. As the avenger of Uthman's death, Muawiyya had the blood stained shirt of Uthman and the fingers chopped off from his wife - when she tried to shield him – displayed in a mosque in a Damascus. This action was meant to stimulate public anger against the regicides and to make Ali an accomplice in the murder of Uthman and hence become disqualified from the caliphate.

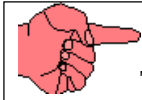
Ali decided to enforce loyalty from Muawiyya and consequently this led to Battle of Siffin on July 28th 657. Sensing defeat, Muawiyya sued for arbitration and hostilities ceased for some time. The issue of the legitimacy to the caliphate was to be settled by two arbiters one from either side. Muawiyya's party had Amr bin al-Aas as the arbiter and the party of Ali had Abu Musa al-Ashari. The decision of the arbiters was not favourable to Ali who was the loser. On the contrary, Muawiyya's was a diplomatic victory for he was just a mere rebel governor. The arbitration had raised Muawiyya to the level of Ali whose position was lowered to that of mere pretender. This increasingly undermined his position as a caliph. Ali decided to pursue the war but experienced so many desertions from his army that he had to abandon his expeditions and returned to Kufa. Both Ali and Muawiyya continued to control areas where they had their influence. Each made internecine incursions into the enemy territory.

However, in Ali's party, there were people who were displeased with his arbitration moves. These people declared that: "no judgement but God's alone". They rejected the role of human arbiters and declared that

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divine judgement could only be expressed through the free choice of the whole community of believers. These people were displeased with Ali's arbitration because Muawiyya and his followers had rebelled against Ali, so he should not have arbitrated with that group. These people deserted from Ali and seceded from his camp. They withdrew to a place called Nahrawan. These people were the "rebels" and were called Kharijites (singular: Khawarij) from the Arabic term "kharaja" – to go out.

Note



The Kharijites was the first sect in Islam.

Attempts by Ali to have the Kharijites back to his party were fruitless and he decided to fight them. In 659, he attacked their camp and almost annihilated them but they rose again under different names and remained a thorn in the flesh of the caliphate till the Abbasid period.

In 661 (CE) Ali was assassinated by a Kharijite, Abdur Rahman ibn Muljam, who was avenging the death of some relatives killed by Ali's forces at Nahrawan. His assassination was a part of a wider plot by the Kharijite to rid the Muslim community on the same day of its three disturbing elements: Ali, Muawiyya and Amr bin al-Aas. After the death of Ali, Muawiyya received general recognition as a caliph after Ali's son Hasan was prevailed upon to forgo his claim to the caliphate.

2.5.4 Summary



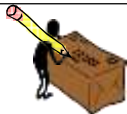
Caliph Ali took over the throne at a time characterised by tensions and internal conflicts in the Muslim community that rose from the death of Uthman. As a result Ali had to contend with political intrigues and battles such as Camel and Siffin that did not spare him any energy to engage in any campaigns of conquest. Instead of Muslims fighting their enemies, they fought amongst themselves. It is therefore not surprising that during the reign of Ali, the expansion of the Muslim state came to an end. The death of Ali brought to an end, the orthodox (patriarchal) caliphate founded by Abu Bakr. The end of the Orthodox Caliphate ushered in the Umayyad Caliphate that was founded by Muawiyya in 661 and which is discussed in Lecture 3.

2.5.5 Key Words



al-fitna: the civil war
Kharijites (Khawarij): the first sect in Islam; a group of extreme puritans who insisted they were the only true believers (Muslims). They fought the mainstream Muslims and their leaders

2.5.6 Activities



- "Al-fitna was a turning point in the history of Islam". Assess the validity of this statement.
- Assess the events that contributed to the battles of the Camel and Siffin.

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2.5.7 Further Reading



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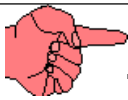
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LECTURE 3: ACHIEVEMENTS UNDER THE ORTHODOX CALIPHATE

3.1 Introduction

In Lecture 2, we looked at each of the four orthodox caliphs, their lives and some of their individual achievements. In this lecture, we will analyse in totality all the achievements of the four orthodox caliphs. We have put emphasis on aspects that were not discussed in Lecture 3.

Note



The era of the Prophet and that of the rightly-guided caliphs is regarded as the "golden age of Islam".

The four caliphs were the rightly guided caliphs or successors to the Prophet and the imams of the Muslims. They dedicated their lives to the cause of Islam and rendered a unique and outstanding service to the Muslim community.

3.2 Objectives



- To analyse the achievements of the four orthodox caliphs.
- To assess why the period of the four orthodox caliphs is regarded as the golden age of Islam.

3.3 Content



What was the nature of the Government?

The caliph was the civil head of the state, chief commander of the army, protector and defender of religion. The caliphs' objectives therefore, were to perpetuate Islam and to see to it that the laws and rules were followed. The caliph ensured that people observed the various religious injunctions in regard to the five daily prayers, suppressed heresies, defended Islam, led in the holy wars, issued decrees/ordinances and educated the masses. He equally made sure that justice was carried out without fear or favour. With all these roles to perform, the office of a caliph required a person of high moral integrity, high standard of piety and righteousness and highly learned person in the Qur'an and *Hadith*; and a person who was fully conversant with religious obligations and practices. So long as these qualities and virtues were manifested in the personalities of the caliphs, their reign remained the "golden age of Islam".

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What about the administration of the empire?

The caliphs were the commanders-in-chief of the army and their duty were to: look after the army and to arrange the distribution of the pay to the soldiers; to lead prayers in the mosque and give *khutba* on Friday; arrange the collection of revenues and keep proper stock of things collected; maintain law and order; look after the moral conduct of the people; to mete out punishment according to the *sharia*; arrange for the proper distribution of the spoils of war among the soldiers and send a fifth to the caliphate's headquarters; provide facilities and security to the pilgrims; distribute pensions to the retired soldiers and look after the family welfare, and to promote agriculture and horticulture.

The empire was divided into several administrative provinces e.g. Mecca, Medina, Syria, Jazira, Basra, Kufa, Egypt and Palestine, Khurasan, Azerbaijan, Persia and Iraq. In some provinces, commanders of the army were also the governors, while in other areas the two institutions were separate. There were districts within the provinces; a collector who headed the police was also the head of each district. Though in some areas, there were separate police officers. There also scribes, police superintendents and treasury officers.

The caliphs appointed an advisory council that consisted of eminent companions. The function of the council was to vet various office bearers and to nominate able and honest persons for various posts. At times the council could consider suggestions and recommendations of such nominations or appointments that came from the provincial governors or district collectors. All senior officers were required to attend Mecca during the time of the annual pilgrimage. People were encouraged to voice their grievances then. During the caliphate of Umar, an office was created to look into complaints against officers, and at times commissions were set up to make on-the-spot enquiries. Delinquent governors or senior officers who assumed an air of pomp or superiority and show were dismissed if they became inaccessible to the people. Examples are Walid bin Uqba who was dismissed on charges of drinking liquor and Abu Musa al-Ashari who was dismissed as the governor of Basra due to his luxurious living. Governors were also dismissed for ineptitude e.g. Amr bin al-Aas, the governor of Egypt was dismissed because he could not increase the state's revenues.



What constituted the economic system?

The economic system established during the time of the Prophet continued to apply during the time of the orthodox caliphate. The main institutions that contributed to the Muslim welfare were the *Bait ul mal* (state treasury), the *ushr* (tithe), the *kharaj* (the land tax), *jizya* (poll-tax), *zakat*. Every property belonging to all Muslims and not to the individuals were the assets of the state (public) treasury. These assets were by the imam for the common interests of the community. The sources of income for the state treasury were *ushr*, *kharaj*, *jizya*, *zakat* (*sadaqat*). Booty obtained in conquests or from enemy, and duty imposed on imported goods, *wakf* (endowment) etc.

Kharaj was imposed on the land of non-Muslims who were allowed to retain their lands after conquests by the Muslim armies. It could be a third, a quarter, or a fifth of the land produce. It could be fixed depending on the produce or money per unit area or per tree. During the reign of Umar, a principle was

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laid down that on conquest of any territory, it would not belong to the soldiers but would be property of the state and people in possession of the land would not be disturbed. The *kharaj* was to be collected in cash and kind and the average produce of several years was reckoned by computing the *kharaj* that was to be collected in three instalments. However the *kharaj* was taken once per year.

Muslims were restrained from purchasing land in conquered areas. This led to the increase in agricultural production for the original owners and the actual cultivators knew much about the cultivation than the nomadic Arabs. This measure ingratiated the Arabs with the local people since they could not rise up in arms against the Arabs. By not engaging in agriculture, the Muslims (Arabs) retained their sterling performance and qualities of valour, bravery, hardiness, and resolute courage.

During the time of Umar, much attention was given to the reclamation of land and promotion of agriculture. Anyone who cultivated a barren land became the owner thereof. If such land was not cultivated within three of occupation, the land reverted to the state. Canals and ponds were dug, bands made and water channels and distributaries provided and a department to look into the extension of irrigation facilities was set up.

Ushr or tithe is the one tenth of the land produce which was taken away from lands belonging to Arabs and those who accepted Islam, land conquered by force and divided among the victorious Muslim armies, or land lying barren and developed for cultivation by caliph's permission. For such lands, a tenth of the produce was taken in the time of the Prophet. Land that was irrigated by rivers, ponds or rainwater and those irrigated by wells were charged one twentieth of the produce. This was continued during the orthodox caliphate.

Caliph Umar introduced duty on imported goods (*ushore*). This tax was levied on articles of trade and was payable by a trader only once per year. *Zakat* and *sadaqat* were alms imposed on Muslims. It was spent on the poor, the needy, collectors of *zakat*, for payment of debts, ransoming of slaves, those to be won over to Islam, for the cause of Allah and for travellers. *Jizya* was paid by the non-Muslims who were under the protection of Muslims. It was paid annually on the basis of income or property. The poor and the low-income earners were exempted. *Jizya* money was spent on equipment, raising of forces, guarding of frontiers, building of fortresses, construction of roads and buildings.



What entailed the judiciary?

Governors and executive officers discharged the judicial duties during the early period of the development of Islamic empire. During the caliphate of Umar, courts were started in all the districts and *kadhis* were appointed. The *kadhis* were supposed to carry out justice and treat everybody equally without distinguishing the rich and the poor, the high and the low. There were no separate courtrooms. The *kadhis* sat and decided cases in mosques. Abu Bakr started the institution of the *mufti*. A *mufti* is a person who is an expert in law and jurisprudence (science and philosophy of law) and he or she is supposed to give authoritative interpretations. The *mufti* was supposed to issue a *fatwa* or a religious decree. Caliph Umar established a department of police. The police officers used to investigate cases, vigilance and to make sure that law and order were maintained.

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What were the achievements in public works?

Umar's rule led to the development of objects of public utility like buildings, canals, roads, bridges and mosques. He expanded the *haram* and the Prophet's mosque at Medina. He built guesthouses and treasuries were opened in strong buildings, fortresses, barracks etc. Under Umar Basra was founded. It developed into a flourishing city that later became a centre for education and learning. He also founded Kufa which expanded to become a seat of learning. The foundations of Cairo as the future capital city of Egypt were laid down during the orthodox caliphate period.



What comprised the military?

During the time of the Prophet and that of the orthodox caliphs orators used to accompany the armies in order to inspire them through Qur'anic recitals. The caliphs appointed commander-in-chiefs of the armies to direct the war campaigns or forces. During the reign of Abu Bakr, there was no standing army: everybody was a warrior in nature and in his own right, and also each person was an expert in archery and swordsmanship. All people gave voluntary service when they were called upon to do so.

The army was composed of cavalry (soldiers who fight on horseback) and infantry (soldiers who fight on foot). The weapons for the cavalry were long spears, swords, helmets and armour; the infantry had small spears, swords, bows, arrows and shields. The role of women in the wars was to nurse the wounded, to give drinking water, beat up drums, tambourines to incite the men. Women rarely participated in actual fighting.

For military purposes, the empire was divided into areas and sub-areas. The headquarters were at Medina, Kufa, Basra, Mosul, Fustat, Damascus, Hems, Jordan and Palestine. Barracks were built in all these places: Kufa, Basra and Fustat were cantonments-permanent military stations. Stables were constructed for the upkeep of horses with pastures for horses and camels being maintained at different places.

Recruits into the army included Arabs and the non-Arabs who had converted to Islam. These were Persians, Indians, Jews and Romans. The soldiers were salaried officials. They also got some of the spoils of war. Soldiers were supposed to be proficient in horsemanship, swimming, to practice archery and to walk bare-footed. This was besides following and understanding various war ethics e.g. not to get on horseback using stirrups, putting on soft clothes, not to avoid sun etc.

Each regiment had its own treasury officer, accounts officer, *kadhi*, translators, physicians and surgeons. In their military campaigns, Muslim forces were by and large successful. These victories could be attributed not to the superiority of their arms, or better organisation, but to the loftiness of their character, excellence of their conduct, steadfastness and endurance that had been promoted by their desert life. In their victories, Muslims did not humiliate their defeated enemies. Instead they were seen as saviours since they allowed their followers to maintain their identity and religion, and their own leaders as long as they paid *jizya*. The policy of Abu Bakr after the end of the *ridda* wars to brought about peace and security. The defeated people were allowed to resume their way of life without fear or harassment.

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Umar set up a permanent department of defence while Uthman carried successful campaigns that extended the Muslim empire thus consolidating the conquests of Umar. He further developed the military system evolved by Umar. He separated the military from the general administration and posted commanders at all important places. Forces were placed at places such as Tripoli, Cyprus and Armenia. Uthman also established the first naval fleet. In his for years, Ali was wholly engaged in constant fighting. He had therefore to re-organise his forces to meet the challenges that he faced.



What were the gains in Education?

The period of the orthodox caliphs witnessed the beginnings of an attentive study of the Qur'an. A category of reciters arose to spread the knowledge of the Qur'an. Different headings and variants in the wording began to appear here and there in the revelations. Uthman decided to have the exact and definitive text of the Qur'an established by a committee of experts. Copies of these were sent to the provincial capitals and orders were given to destroy all other collections of the texts from the Qur'an, whether complete or fragmentary. The Qur'anic text that has come down to Muslims has not undergone any modifications since those days.

The study of the Qur'an led to the reflections on the language of the Qur'an i.e. Arabic, as an aid to better comprehension, to a study of meanings that might be attached to words and phrases, and to investigation of the circumstances in which each revelation was made. With time, different kinds of sciences and exegeses emerged. The *hadith* and the *sunna* of the Prophet were also studied.

3.2 Summary



In this lecture we have analysed the achievements of the four rightly guided caliphs. These caliphs acted as the sovereign heads of state in their respective periods. They protected and defended Islam and also made an effort to uplift the socio-economic conditions of the *umma*. The achievements of the caliphs are evident in the various spheres of government, administration, judiciary, military, public works and education. Indeed it was through the leadership qualities, the way they managed the affairs of the state and achievements that the four caliphs have been aptly described as “the rightly guided caliphs” and their period in history described as “the golden age of Islam”.

3.4 Key Words



Bait ul mal: state treasury

fatwa (pl.fatawa): religious decree(s)/official ruling(s) on a point of Islamic law

Hadith (pl. *ahadith*): recorded traditions about the sayings and deeds of the Prophet Muhammad and his companions

Kadhi: judge/magistrate

Kharaj: land tax

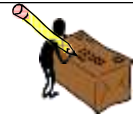
Khutba: sermon

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<i>Mufti:</i>	a jurist; expert in law
<i>sunna:</i>	literally, a “way of life, actions and tacit approval and conduct of the Prophet Muhammad/tradition of the Muslim community based on the example of the Prophet and the Companions
<i>ushore:</i>	duty on imported goods
<i>Ushr:</i>	tithe
<i>Waqf:</i>	religious endowment

3.5 Activities



- Why was the period of the “four rightly guided caliphs” so called?
- Account for the emergence of the four rightly guided caliphs.
- “The golden age of Islam”. How is this statement an appropriate description of the reign of the four orthodox caliphs?
- Analyse the major achievements of the four orthodox caliphs.

3.6 Further Reading



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LECTURE 4: THE Umayyad CALIPHATE (661-750 CE)

Lesson 4.1 The Rise of the Umayyads

4.1.1 Introduction

The death of Ali, the fourth and last orthodox caliph ushered in the Umayyad dynasty, the first dynasty in Islam. This lesson examines the rise of the Umayyad dynasty and its consolidation under various rulers, the outbreak of the second civil war, the administration and achievements of the Umayyad dynasty and its fall in 750 CE.

4.1.2 Objectives

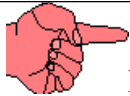


- To analyse the rise of the Umayyads to power.
- Evaluate the factors that contributed to the outbreak of the second civil war.

4.1.3 Content

Muawiyya son of Abu Sufyan was proclaimed the caliph in Jerusalem in 660 CE. The transfer of the seat of Government from Medina to Damascus followed afterwards. The Umayyad era was imperialistic, dynastic and dominated by the Arab military aristocracy. From their headquarters in Damascus, the Umayyads developed a strong centralized government, an Arab empire whose boundaries extended to Spain in the west and the borders of China in the east.

Note



Muawiyya's reign (661-680 CE) was the longest period of peace and prosperity in the annals of the Umayyad caliphate.

This period witnessed the consolidation and extension of the territories of the caliphate. The Muslim empire expanded to North Africa under the command of Uqba bin Nafi, who established a military colony at Qairawan ("the place of arms") in Morocco. Similar conquests were undertaken on Khurasan (663-671) and Turkestan (674). Egypt was peaceful and Iraq was kept under firm control by a series of ruthless and competent generals – Mughira, Ziyad and al-Hajjaj. Ziyad was successful in curbing disaffection in Basrah and Kufa.

To extend the limits of his empire, Muawiyya relied heavily on Syrian Christians and Syrian Arabs. As a reputed military organizer, Muawiyya abolished many of the traditional features of government. He built a stable, well organized government administrative machinery. He is credited with instituting a bureau of registry and had an interest in postal services that were later developed under Abd al-Malik into a well-organized system that knitted together various parts of the far-flung empire.

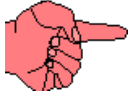
Muawiyya chose his son Yazid as heir apparent. Yazid took over after the death of his father in 680 (CE). On his ascension to the throne, Hussein the son of Ali and Abdallah bin Zubair refused to recognize Yazid as the caliph and the second civil in Islam broke out.

The Second Civil War

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The second civil war broke out in 680 when Hussein and Abdallah rallied their forces and resisted Yazid's enthronement. What followed was the Battle of Kerbala in which an insignificant force of Hussein was massacred when they refused to surrender. The massacre of Hussein and his forces at Kerbala became the root of Shi'ite schism that was born on the 10th of *Muharram*. The Shi'a Muslims were henceforth provided with a martyr.

Note



The day of Hussein's martyrdom gave the Shi'ites a battle cry that was summed up in the formula: "vengeance for Hussein" This massacre was one of the factors which undermined the Umayyad Caliphate.

Meanwhile, Abdallah bin Zubair continued to rouse opposition against the Umayyads in the holy cities. When reconciliation failed, Yazid sent an army to Arabia where he routed the insurgents. The Syrian troops entered Medina and in August 683 (CE) and routed the city. They later moved to Mecca to deal with Abdallah who had taken refuge there. Fighting which ensued resulted in the *ka'aba* catching fire and it was burned into the ground. The Black Stone was split into three pieces and the house of Allah according to Saunders (1965), looked like "the torn bosoms of mourning women". Yazid died when these operations were going on, and they had to be called off. The second civil in Islam was temporary halted. Yazid ruled only for three years. His reign was disastrous to Muslims as it experienced the tragedy of Kerballa.



Who succeeded Yazid?

Muawiyya II (683)

After the death of Yazid and the withdrawal of the Syrian troops from Mecca, Abdallah bin Zubair was proclaimed the caliph in Arabia and Iraq. Meanwhile, Muawiyya II, the 21 year old, ailing son of Yazid succeeded him. He ruled for only three months and died leaving no successor. Some sources say that, Muawiyya II was so saddened by the tragedy of Kerballa that he abdicated the throne without leaving a successor.

Marwan bin Hakam (683-685)

In 684, with the help of the Qalbites (Syrian Arabs), Marwan bin Hakam, the cousin of Uthman and formerly his Secretary of State became the founder of the Marwanid branch of the Umayyad dynasty. He ruled for two years and was succeeded by his son Abd al-Malik.

Abd al-Malik (685-705 CE)

The legitimacy of Abd al-Malik to the caliphate was not recognized outside Syria and Egypt.

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What were the reasons for that?

This was because Iraq and Arabia recognized Abdallah as the genuine caliph. The Kharijites on the other hand caused a lot of chaos in most provinces. The uprising in Kufa following the death of Hussein transformed the Shi'a from a political party into a religious sect. The Kufans swore to avenge the sufferings of the house of Ali. The leadership of this cause (vengeance) fell on Mukhtar of Ta'if who proclaimed himself the ambassador of Muhammad bin Hanafiyya (an alleged son of Ali by a woman of Banu Hanifa) who though not a direct descendant of Ali was selected as the only available adult of Ali's side to have survived the massacre of Kerbala. The death of Hussein and the transformation of the Shi'a into a sect are discussed in details in Lesson 6.2.

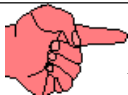
Mukhtar's message propounded the cause for the house of Ali, for the caliphate. His message caught the ears of the non-Arab Muslims (*Mawalis*) who resented their inferior status and the arrogance of the Arab rulers. He assured them of the imminent coming of a Messiah (*Mahdi*- the rightly guided one) who restore truth and virtue, remove all distinctions of class and race and gather all the believers in a community of equals. The *Mawalis* became a political force that threatened the prevailing status quo.

The struggle of power between the various contestants - Abd al-Malik, Abdallah and Mukhtar – turned Iraq into a battleground. Abd al-Malik's attempts to gain control of this area were thwarted by Mukhtar when the Umayyad troops were defeated in 686. After this defeat, the followers of two contestants – Abdullah and Muhammad Hanafiyya (under Mukhtar) turned on one another. The war that arose led to the death of Mukhtar and his chief supporters in 687 (CE).

In 691, Abd al-Malik marched against the forces of Abdallah – under the command of his brother Mus'ab – in Iraq. Consequently, Mu'sab was killed and Kufa surrendered. The Bedouin chiefs swore allegiance to Abd al-Malik. Muhammad Hanafiyya decided not follow his claims and he was left alone by Abd al-Malik. Abdallah was besieged in Mecca by General Al-Hajjaj and died in combat. His death led to the Syrians' occupation of Mecca. This marked the end of the second civil war and Abd al-Malik, reigned uninterrupted thereafter.

Abd al-Malik engaged in imperialistic expansion. Within a period of 20 years, this expansion saw the addition of North Africa, Spain and Transoxiana to the Islamic empire. Abd al-Malik had to contend with so many enemies but he managed to subdue them. By the time of his death in 705 CE, he passed to his son and successor, Al-Walid, a consolidated and pacified empire that included not only the whole of the Islamic world but also new conquests of his own.

Note



Under Abd al-Malik and his four sons – Al Walid (705-715), Suleiman (715-717), Yazid II (720-724), and Hisham (724-743) – the Umayyad Empire is supposed to have realized its golden age.

Under the reign of Abd al-Malik, various achievements were realized. Besides the expansion of the Muslim Empire, the process of Arabicization of the state was started. It continued well into the reign of

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al-Walid. Arabization involved changing of the language of public registers from Greek to Arabic in Damascus and from Pahlavi (ancient Persian language) to Arabic in Iraq and the eastern provinces, and of an Arabic coinage. The first coins were made of silver and gold with Arabic inscriptions. The first coins of this nature appeared in Damascus in 695 (CE).

The administration of the empire was arabicized by Abd al-Malik. He also developed regular postal services using relays of horses for the conveyance of travelers and dispatches between Damascus and provincial capitals. The postal service was meant to meet the needs of the government officials and their correspondence. The postmasters were charged with the duties of keeping the caliph posted on all important happenings and events in their respective provinces.

In 691, Abd al-Malik erected the Dome of Rock in order to divert the pilgrimage from Mecca that was held by his rival Abdallah bin Zubair. This structure was restored by the Abbasid caliph al-Ma'mun (813-833) who unscrupulously substituted his name for that of Abd al-Malik but inadvertently forgot to change the date. Abd al-Malik also built the *al-Masjid al-Aqsa* (the Farther Mosque) which today ranks as the third holiest shrine after the ones in Mecca and Medina.

Al-Walid (705-715 CE)

He succeeded his father Abd al-Malik when he died in 705 (CE). He is reputed to have been the greatest Umayyad builder.



Why was this so?

He enlarged and beautified the Great Mosque at Mecca, rebuilt that of Medina and erected a number of schools and mosques in Syria. He endowed institutions for lepers, the lame and the blind. Probably, he was the medieval ruler to put up hospitals for chronic diseases and many lazaret houses – for the poor, lepers and diseased – which later grew in the West followed the Muslim precedent. His great achievement was the conversion in Damascus of the site of Cathedral of St. John the Baptist, which he seized from his Christian subjects, into one of the most sublime places of worship in the world. This mosque is today considered as the fourth holiest shrine of Islam after Mecca, Medina and Jerusalem.

Suleiman (715-717 CE)

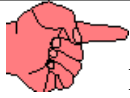
Caliph Suleiman succeeded his brother Al-Walid. He built in Palestine the ruins of a more ancient town, the city of al-Ramlah that made his residence. Traces of his palace could be seen up to the time of World War I. The minaret of his white mosque – which was the third holiest shrine of Syria after the Mosque of Damascus and the Dome of the Rock – rebuilt by the Mamluks (former slaves who established a dynasty in Egypt) - in the 14th century still stands.

Umar (bin Abdul Aziz) II (717-720 CE)

He was a cousin of Suleiman. He was a devoted Muslim who wanted Muslims to follow the Islamic way of life. He enjoyed the reputation of piety and asceticism that greatly contrasted with the impiety of the Umayyads. He was regarded as the Umayyad saint due to his piety. He led a simple and austere life devoid of luxuries that befitted a caliph. He discontinued the practice established by the time of Muawiyya of cursing Ali from the pulpit at the Friday prayers.

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Note



His piety saved his grave from the desecration that was meted upon the tombs of Umayyads by the Abbasids caliphs.

On his ascension, he decreed that on conversion to Islam, a person would not be required to pay poll tax. This action led to wide spread conversions to Islam. To protect the interests of the minorities, he decreed that no Muslim could purchase land from a non-Muslim.

It was during the reign of Umar II that al-Hajjaj, the school teacher turned military genius and governor of Arabia, encouraged the construction of canals. He drained and tilled submerged or uncultivated lands. He contributed to the development of diacritical marks in Arabic orthography to distinguish such similarly written letters as *ba'*, *ta'*, *tha'*, *dal*, *dhal* and the adaptation from Syriac of vowels *dammah* (u), *fathah* (a) and *kasra* (i) which are inserted above and below the consonants. This orthographic reform was prompted by the desire to prevent errors in the recitation of the Qur'an that he evidently prepared a critical revision.

Due to his policies that affected some vested interests, Umar II was poisoned to death in 720 CE, when he was only 39 years old. During his reign, peace and prosperity prevailed through out the Muslim empire.

Yazid II

He was the third son of Abd al-Malik and he succeeded Umar II. Though he had promised to follow the footsteps of his predecessor, he failed miserably as he indulged in pleasure and frivolities. He died after 4 year's reign. Historians have dismissed him as a weak and indifferent ruler with shallow and unimpressive character.

Hisham (724-743 CE)

He was the fourth son of Abd al-Malik who succeeded his brother Yazid II. He ruled for 19 years. He was a successful ruler and the empire realized prosperity during his reign. He was the last great ruler of the Umayyads and with him came the end of the golden age of the Umayyad.

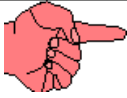
Walid II, Yazid III and Ibrahim (743-744 CE) and Marwan II (743-750 CE).

Hisham was succeeded by his nephew Walid II son of Yazid II, the predecessor of Hisham. Walid II's rule barely lasted a year. He was extravagant and immoral who drunk a lot and married his fathers maids. Yazid III whose life contrasted a great deal with the immorality and profligacy of his predecessor succeeded Walid II. However, he barely ruled for 6 months and was succeeded by his brother Ibrahim in 744 CE. The years 743-744 CE were characterized by anarchy. This was a short period of 2 years within which as many as three caliphs ascended the throne. Once a united family, the Umayyads were now fighting amongst themselves. This considerably weakened the foundations of the Umayyad dynasty that was now approaching its sunset. Marwan II (743-750 CE) came to throne when the process of disintegration had taken roots in the empire. The Abbasids, Khorasanians (Mawalis) and the Shia altogether put a lot of pressure on the Umayyads through a series of revolts that eventually brought the Umayyad dynasty to its knees.

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Note



The following is a list of the Umayyad caliphs:

1. Muawiyya	661-680	2. Yazid	680-683
3. Muawiyya II	683	4. Marwan I	683-685
5. Abd al-Malik	685-705	6. Al-Walid I	705-715
7. Suleiman	715-717	8. Umar II	717-720
9. Yazid II	720-724	10. Hisham	724-743
11. Al-Walid	743-744	11. Yazid III	744
12. Ibrahim	744	13. Marwan II	744-750

4.1.4 Summary



In this lesson we have examined the rise of the Umayyads and identified and discussed the various Umayyad caliphs. The Umayyad rule lasted for 90 years and the dynasty produced 13 rulers. Though the Umayyads are rated for the expansion of Muslim domains, their reign witnessed the conversion of the Islamic polity into a hereditary monarchy. The dynasty also witnessed the development of sectarianism in Islam. This is evident in the transformation of the Shi'a into a sect and the proliferation of the various extremist groups of the Kharijites.

4.1.5 Key Words

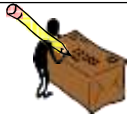


Mahdi: the rightly guided; a kind of a messianic figure who is believed will come at the end of time to establish justice and rule of God on earth.

This belief is very strong among the Shi'a Muslims

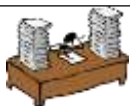
Mawalis: the neo-Muslims (clients) or the non-Arab converts to Islam, who were invariably Persians

4.1.6 Activities



- Analyse the rise of the Umayyads to power in 660 CE.
- “Muawiyya contributed more to Arabism than to Islam during his reign”. Discuss.
- Why is Al-Walid I (705-715 CE) considered the greatest Umayyad builder?
- Discuss the role played by Muawiyya, Abdul al-Malik and his four sons in the expansion of the Umayyad dynasty. Why were the subsequent Umayyad caliphs unable to play a similar role?

4.1.6 Further Reading



Esposito, J.L. 1984. Islam and Politics, p.9
Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**, pp.151-186
Hawting, G.R.© 1986. **The First Dynasty of Islam: The Umayyad Caliphate A.D 661-750**. London & Sydney, pp.1-24, 46-57, 90-103
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Lewis, B. 1993. The Arabs in History, pp. 65-83

Lesson 4.2 Administration Under the Umayyads

4.2.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson, we have looked at the rise of the Umayyads to power. We have also seen the efforts of the various Umayyad caliphs in consolidating their rule. In this lesson, we will examine the administration of the Umayyads. The administrative machinery of the Umayyads enabled them to have a grip on the Muslim empire for close to ninety years.

4.2.2 Objectives

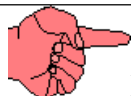


- To examine the administrative machinery of the Umayyads.
- To discuss the nature of the Umayyad society.

4.2.3 Content

The foundation of the Umayyad unity was the establishment of an Arab monarchy and the reliance upon an Arab warrior aristocracy. Legitimate succession was made hereditary and was restricted to the house of the Umayyads. This was contrary to the practice of the Prophet and the first four caliphs.

Note



In spite of its Islamic character, the Umayyad society was based upon the creation and the perpetuation of an Arab aristocracy with a hereditary social caste. The Arabs were the heart of the Umayyads powerful military machine and the source of their power and security.

The administration of the empire was more centralised. The caliph was the head of the state, which he supervised. He was assisted by a bureaucracy composed of departments or ministries that were responsible in overseeing the collection of taxes, lands, rents, payment of officials, military and public works. Centralisation and militarization of the state led to increased autocratic and absolute government supported and protected by an Arab aristocracy. The law aided centralization, arabicization and islamicization. The administrative divisions of the Umayyads and to a larger extent those of the Abbasids corresponded in general to the provinces of the preceding Byzantine and Persian empires.



Which were these provinces?

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They were: Syria; Kufa/Iraq; Basra/Persia, Sijistan, Khurasan, al-Bahrayn, Oman, Najd; Armenia; Hijaz; Karman-the frontiers districts of India; Egypt; Ifriqqiyya; Yemen. In these provinces, political administration, tax collection, religious leadership were under the direction of the following officers:

- The Viceroy (*Sahib/Amir*) was in charge of the military and political administration in the province
- Agent/Prefect (*amil*) was appointed by the viceroy as his representative over a district
- Special Officer was responsible over revenues. The first such officer was appointed during the reign of Muawiyyah I.

The Umayyads also borrowed from existing foreign institutions and practices that they adapted or added to such practices. For example, they created the judicial institutions of a:

➤ **Market Inspector**

A Byzantine institution, the Umayyad adapted this institution by expanding the office through adding an Islamic dimension in which religious or moral principles of Islam were to be observed. The market supervisor was a supervisor of public morals. He checked defective weights, measures, fraudulent business practices and public observance of the fast of Ramadhan among others

➤ **Judge/Sharia courts:**

The Umayyads expanded the institution of the *kadhi*. He was a representative/legal secretary of the provincial governor, a member of his administration. He was responsible in overseeing the implementation of government decrees and settling disputes. He also decided cases and administered pious foundations like the *waqf* (endowment), estates of the orphans and imbeciles. By the end of the Umayyad caliphate, the office of the *qadhi* had become separate and a distinct government position that of a judge responsible for the enforcement of the *sharia*. This laid the foundation of the *sharia* courts.

The judicial officers were appointed by the governor only and during the Abbasids appointment were made by the caliphs. During the reign of Muawiyya, there was a regular series of judges who were recruited from the *faqih* class whose members were scholars learned in the Quran and the traditions.

Muawiyya had created a bureau of registry, a kind of a state chancery (office of public records). This he did after he realised that some of his signed correspondence was being forged. The duty of the chancery was to make and preserve one copy of each official document before sealing and dispatching the original. By the time of Abd al-Malik, a state archives had been established in Damascus.

Military

The Umayyad army was modelled in its organization after that of the Byzantines. The division was of 5 corps: Centre, 2 wings, vanguard and rearguard. This plan was continued until the reign of Marwan II (744-750) who abandoned the old division and introduced the small compact body called the Cohort.

Revenue

The main sources of state's revenue remained as they were under the orthodox caliphate. Chief among them was tax from the conquered peoples.

Population

The population of the Umayyad Empire was divided into four social classes.



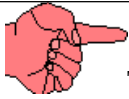
Which were these?

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(a) The first were the Arabs – the ruling Muslims - who consisted of the household of the caliph and the aristocracy of the Arab conquerors. The Arabs were the recipients of the enormous wealth accrued from military conquests. They enjoyed special tax privileges. They were exempted from the taxes that were levied on non-Arab Muslims and the non-Muslims. They only paid *zakat* and tithe (*ushr*) on land. This preferential treatment brought about discontents from the non-Arab Muslims and a need to overthrow the Umayyad dynasty.

(b) The second group were the neo-Muslims or clients (*Mawalis*) who by force or persuasion had accepted Islam and theoretically, not practically, admitted to the full rights of the Islamic citizenship. However Arabian chauvinism made these rights difficult to achieve. The *Mawalis* formed the lowest stratum of Muslim society, a status they bitterly resented. Their bitterness made them to support any opposition against the Arabian hegemony. The *Mawalis* were the first to devote themselves to learned studies and fine arts. They outshone the Arabs in the intellectual field and this made them to start contesting with them the political leadership.

Note



Through intermarriages with the Arabs, the *Mawalis* diluted the Arabian blood and ultimately made the blood element inconspicuous amidst the mixture of varied races

(c) The third group was made up of the tolerated sects called *ahl-Dhimmah* (*Dhimmis*). These were Christians, Jews and Sabians (Christians of St. John – Q. sura 2:262; 5:72). These people paid tribute in recognition of the protection rendered to them by Muslims. They enjoyed a wide measure of toleration against the payment of taxes and also enjoyed religious freedom under their own religious leaders. Later the status of tolerated sects was extended to Zoroastrians (Magians) and the North African Berbers.

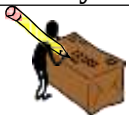
(d) At the bottom of society were the slaves. Islam preserved the ancient Semitic institution of slavery but it appreciably ameliorated the condition of slaves. A Muslim was not supposed to enslave a fellow Muslim. Slaves in early Islam were recruited from prisoners of wars, women and children, unless ransomed, and by purchase or raiding.

4.2.4 Summary



In this lesson we have examined the administration of the Umayyad Empire. Specifically we have looked at the main features of the Umayyad administration that include: provinces, judicial institutions, military, revenue and the population. Most importantly, it is noted that the Umayyad administration promoted the superiority of the Arab race, a factor that weakened its hold on power and later contributed to its downfall.

4.2.5 Activity



Discuss the main features of the Umayyad administration.

4.2.6 Further Reading



Esposito, J.L. 1984. Islam and Politics, pp. 13-14.
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Hitti, P.K. 1973. The History of the Arabs. London: Macmillan, pp. 317
Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, pp. 83-91.

Lesson 4.2 Achievements of the Umayyads

4.2.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we examined the Umayyad administration. In today's lesson we will assess the main achievements of the Umayyad dynasty.

4.2.2 Objective



To discuss the main achievements of the Umayyad dynasty.

4.2.3 Content

The following were the main achievements of the Umayyad dynasty:

(a) Expansion of Islam

The Umayyads inaugurated a second age of conquest and consolidated Islam in the lands of the first conquests. Islam became rooted in the lands that had been the cradle of Christianity. By 732, which marked the first centenary of the Prophet's death, Muslims were the masters of an empire greater than that of Rome at its zenith, an empire extending from the Bay of Biscay to the Indus and the confines of China, and from the Aral Sea to the lower cataracts of the Nile. This was an area comprising South Western Europe, North Africa, Western Central Asia and the Middle East, the heartland of Islam.

(b) Administration

The government machinery that was to a large extent crude and impoverished under the orthodox caliphs acquired a more elaborate and efficient character under the Umayyads. Administrative departments increased. From the original war office created by Caliph Umar, was added a tax office and a secretariat that received, filed and answered the caliphs' correspondence. There was a privy seal where copies of state documents were kept and out-going letter were sealed to prevent forgery. A post office organized by Abd al-Malik and used for the conveyance of news and orders by relays of horsemen over the vast empire.

(c) Arabization

Under the Umayyads, especially during the reign of Abd al-Malik, Arabic became the official language of the government. The administration of Iraq was arabicized in 697; Syria in 700 and Egypt in 705. Coins bearing Greek and Persian inscriptions with effigies of Byzantine and Sassanid rulers which were in circulation since the conquests were withdrawn in 696 and replaced by Arabic coins stamped with phrases or quotations from the Qur'an.

(d) Construction of Mosques and Works of Public Utility

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The Umayyads promoted the construction of mosques in all the principal cities of the empire as a way of expressing Muslim art. Abd al-Malik built the magnificent Dome of the Rock in Jerusalem in 691. The Dome is a living symbol of Islamic faith. It is one of the earliest monuments surviving. He also put up the Aqsa Mosque that was not far from the Dome. However, the term *al-masjid al-aqsa* is used in general to include the whole collection of sacred buildings comprising the Dome, the tombs, *dervish* monasteries (*zawiyahs*) erected by many caliphs from Abd al-Malik to the Ottoman Sultan Suleiman. This is an area that covers about 34 acres.

In 705, Al-Walid I (705-715) built the Umayyad Mosque on the site of the Basilica of Damascus dedicated to St. John. The Umayyads introduced the *minaret* and the *mihrab*. The minaret is the place from which the Muslims are called to prayer. Many minarets were introduced in Syria and Arabia by Al-Walid I. His governor, Umar introduced the minaret into the Medina Mosque. Governors of Muawiyya introduced the minarets in Egypt and Basra mosque. The *mihrab* is a recess or niche in the wall that indicates the direction of Mecca (prayer). Either Umar II or Al-Walid I and (or) Muawiyya are credited with the introduction of the *mihrab*. The first *mihrab* was put in the Medinan Mosque, but later it became a common feature of all mosques.

(e) Culture and Intellectual Development

During the Umayyad Caliphate, Mecca and Medina became the home of music and song, love and poetry. Iraq cities of Kufa and Basra developed into intellectual centers.

- In Basra, the scientific study of Arabic language and grammar was started. This was necessitated by the new Muslim converts who wanted to study the Qur'an, hold government positions and converse with the Arab masters. There was also a need to fill the widening gap between classical Arabic and everyday vernacular corrupted by Syriac, Persian and other languages and dialects
- Apart from sponsoring the study of Arabic, the Umayyads preside over or sponsored the systematization of the law and the collection of Hadith. The study of the Qur'an and *Hadith* provided the foundation of the theology and *Fiqh*. Abu Hanifa, the founder of the Hanafi School of *Fiqh*, one of the four schools of Sunni law, lived during the tail end of the Umayyad dynasty.
- The study of the Qur'an and the need to expound it gave rise to philology (study of the development of a language) and lexicography (dictionary compiling) and the science of *Hadith*.
- Arabic historiography began at the time of the Umayyads. This started in the form of traditions (*Hadith*). The interest in gathering old stories of the Prophet and the companions became the basis of *Sirah* (Biography).
- During this period, those who sought education secured it in the mosques that they patronized. Education in the mosques centred on the Qur'an and Hadith. The earliest readers were the Qur'an readers.
- But the greatest intellectual measure of progress that was achieved during the Umayyad Caliphate was in the area of poetical composition. Arabic lyric (poetry that expresses emotional feelings), poetry, political poetry made their appearance and flourished under the Umayyads. Attempts were also made to compile ancient pre-Islamic poetry.

(f) Public Speaking - Oratory

The art of public speaking (oratory) was cultivated during the Umayyad period. It was used as an instrument of religion in Friday sermons. Generals also used it to arouse military enthusiasm among their troops and provincial governors used it to instill a sense of patriotism to their subjects.

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(g) Development of Religio-philosophical movements

The Umayyad period also witnessed the development of religio-philosophical movements like the *Mutazilites* whose school of theology was founded on rationalism. The *Mutazilites* flourished under the Abbasids. This period also witnessed the development of sects like the *Kharijites*, the *Murjites* (those who suspended judgment) and the *Shi'ites*.

Greek philosophical ideas found their way into Islam during the era of the Umayyads. This was seen for example in the *Mutazilites*, mentioned above. St. John of Damascus, the last of the Greek fathers was an agent of Christian lore and Greek thought. He wrote in Greek and was a Syrian who was versed in Arabic and Aramaic. As a hymnologist, theologian, orator, polemic writer, father of the Byzantine music and codifier of the Byzantine art, he stood as an ornament to the body of the Church under the caliphate. Through his works, he criticized Islam from the standpoint of Christian orthodoxy.

4.2.4 Summary



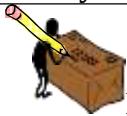
This lesson has discussed the main achievements of the Umayyad dynasty. These achievements are evident in the following areas: expansion of Islam; administration; arabicization; construction of mosques and works of public utility; culture and intellectual development; oratory and development of religio-philosophical movements such as the *Kharijites*, *Shi'ites* and *Mutazilites*.

4.2.5 Key Words



mihrab: recess or niche in the wall that indicates the direction of Mecca (prayer)
minaret: the pillars of a mosque from which Muslims are called to prayer
zawiyahs: sufi centres

4.2.6 Activity



Discuss the main achievements of the Umayyad dynasty (660-750 CE).

4.2.7 Further Reading



Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**, pp.193
Hawting, G.R.© 1986. **The First Dynasty of Islam**, pp. 104-119
Hitti, P.K. 1973. The History of the Arabs, pp.207-218
Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, pp. 83- 91

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Lesson 4.4 The Decline and Fall of the Umayyads

4.4.1 Introduction

Having discussed the achievements of the Umayyad dynasty, let us now trace the decline of the Umayyads and assess the reasons that contributed to this decline and eventual fall.

4.4.2 Objectives



- To assess the reasons for the decline and fall of the Umayyad dynasty.
- To account the events that led to the fall of the Umayyad dynasty.

4.4.3 Content

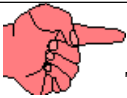


What were reasons for the fall of the Umayyad Dynasty?

(a) The Qaysite-Qalbite Conflict

The Arab tribes traced their descent from either Adnan or Kahtan. Adnan was the forefather of the Northern Arabs whose most noteworthy tribe was the Banu Mudar and the Qays clan was, which gave their name to the entire group, was the leading one. The Northern Arabs had migrated to Iraq and settled along the Euphrates.

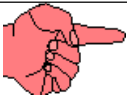
Note



The term Qaysite (Qays) became synonymous with the Northern Arabs.

The Southern Arabs on the other hand descended from Kahtan and they were commonly regarded as Yemenites. Many of them migrated northwards and settled in Syria. Among them were the Qalbs who being the leading faction, their name was used as the rallying cry for their party.

Note



The term Qalbites (Qalbs) became synonymous with the Yemenites or Southern Arabs.

Rivalry between the Qays and Qalbs was ancient and endemic and with the coming of Islam, the bond of race was replaced by that of religion. In time, there was an alignment of the Northerners against the Southerners. The Qays became the nucleus of one party and the Qalbs, the nucleus of the other.



How was the rivalry between the Qays and Qalbs manifested in the Umayyad leadership?

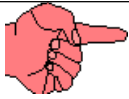
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The Yemenites (Southerners) supported Muawiyya (660-680 CE) owing to his marriage to a Christian Qalbite woman by the name Maysun. Yazid (680-683 CE) also married a Qalbite woman and this brought jealous from the Qaysites who refused to recognize Yazid's successor Muawiyya II. The Qaysites had accused Yazid of favoring the Qalbites (Yemenites) and consequently they deserted him in support of his rival Abdullah Zubair who they acknowledged as the caliph. The ascension of Marwan to the caliphate after the death of Muawiyya II was seen as a victory of the Qalbites over the Qaysites. When Marwan was accepted as caliph in Syria, the Qaysites remained sullen, discontented and un-reconciled and this weakened the foundation of the Umayyad power and dynasty.

During the reign of al-Walid (705-715), the Qaysite power was at its peak. This was due to the conquests of al-Hajjaj and those of his cousin Muhammad in India, and Qutaybah the conqueror of India. Suleiman (715-717), the brother and successor of al-Walid favored the Qalbites. Yazid II (720- 724) favored the Qaysites due to his Qaysite wife. Yazid III (744) relied on the Qalbite arms to usurp the throne from al-Walid II (743-744) his predecessor.

Note



A scenario was therefore created where individual caliphs gave patronage to individual parties or tribes. The caliph acted as a head of a particular part instead of head of a united empire.

The polarization of the empire into the Arab dualism of Qaysites and Qalbites precipitated the downfall of the Umayyad dynasty. Conflicts between the two groups brought about pitched battles in areas such as Damascus, Spain, Lebanon and Palestine.

(b) The Succession Problem

Lack of definite and fixed rule of hereditary succession to the caliphate caused national disturbance. Muawiyya nominated his son Yazid as successor but the age-old Arab principle of seniority in succession conflicted with hereditary succession of a father to son. Four of the Umayyad caliphs had their sons as their immediate successors. These were Muawiyya (661-680), Yazid (680-683), Marwan I (683-685) and Abd al-Malik (685-705). Marwan I designated his son Abd al-Malik as his successor followed by his other son Abd al-Aziz. This precedent complicated an already complicated problem. On his part, Abd al-Malik deprived his brother Abd al-Aziz of throne by designating his own son Al-Walid as his successor followed by his other son Suleiman as the second nominee. Al-Walid also attempted unsuccessfully to deprive his brother Suleiman his right to the throne by appointing his son as heir apparent. These maneuvers could not augur well for the stability and continuity of the dynasty.

(c) The Shi'ites

They regarded the Umayyads as usurpers and did not forget the ills and wrongs perpetuated on Ali and his family especially the martyrdom of Hussein. The Shi'ites became the focus of public sympathy and all those who were politically, socially and economically discontented with the Umayyads joined the Shi'ite camp. The Umayyads were accused of worldliness and neglecting Qur'anic and the *sharia*. The Shi'ites were ready to give religious legitimacy to any opposition that could be raised against the Umayyads.

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(d) The Abbasid Claimants

The Abbasids were descendants of an uncle of the Prophet Al-Abbas ibn Abdallah Muttalib. They also pressed their claim to the throne and made a common cause with the Alids by emphasizing the rights of the house of Hashim. The Abbasids regarded themselves closer to the Prophet than the Umayyads. The Abbasids took advantage of the widespread discontent and posed as defenders of the true faith. They became the champions and leaders of the anti-Umayyad cause.

(e) The Khorasanians

The non-Arab Muslims (*Mawalis*) and the Persians in particular were dissatisfied with the Umayyads because they were not accorded economic and social equality like the Arab counterparts. At times they experienced the heavy taxation burden that was levied on non-Muslims. Among these *Mawalis*, the doctrines of the *Shi'ites* spread like a whirlwind.



How did the reasons discussed above lead to the fall of the Umayyads?

All the various opposition groups wanted the Muslim empire to stop being a society of Arabs bound together by Islam and to become a society of Muslims who used the Arabic language and respected parts of Arabic heritage. They condemned the Umayyad policies and practices as un-Islamic innovations and called for a return to the Qur'an and the practices of the Prophet and early community.

A coalition was formed between the *Shi'ites*, *Khorasanians* and the Abbasid forces. On June 9 747, a revolt broke out in Khorasan when the Abbasid agent, Abu Muslim a Persian freed slave took over the capital Marw with the help of the *Mawalis* and the Iranian peasants. Attempts to appeal for help from Marwan II (744-750) were futile as he was experiencing an uprising that had risen from the Qaysite-Qalbite conflict. This conflict had been exploited by ambitious aspirants to the caliphate and assumed the dimensions of a civil war under Yazid II (744) and Ibrahim (744). Marwan II was favoured by the *Qaysites* and therefore alienated most of his *Qalbite* sympathizers. On the other hand, the *Kharijites* openly rebelled against Marwan II. There were also feuds in Spain that added to an already volatile situation.

With the fall of Marw, Kufa the leading city of Iraq fell to the insurgents in 749. Abu al-Abbas a great grandson of Al-Abbas the uncle of the Prophet was declared the first Abbasid caliph at Kufa on Thursday October 30, 749.

4.4.4 Summary



This lesson has assessed the reasons that contributed to the decline of the Umayyads and the events that eventually led to the fall of the dynasty. It could be argued that the reasons that led to the fall of the Umayyad dynasty could be traced from the Qaysite-Qalbite conflict. This conflict undermined the foundation of the Umayyad power, a situation that was taken advantage of by the various forces that were opposed to the Umayyad administration.

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4.4.5 Activities



- The reasons for the fall of the Umayyad dynasty could be traced from the Qaysite-Qalbite conflict. Discuss.
- Assess the factors that contributed to the fall of the Umayyad dynasty in 750 CE.

4.4.6 Further Reading



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LECTURE 5: THE ABBASID DYNASTY 750-1258 CE

Lesson 5.1 The Rise of the Abbasids

5.1.1 Introduction

In spite of their various achievements, the Umayyads fell in 750 after a rule of close to ninety years. With the fall of the Umayyads, the Abbasids who were the descendants of al-Abbas the uncle of the Prophet came to power. This lesson analyses the rise of the Abbasids to power and how various Abbasid caliphs consolidated their rule after the fall of the Umayyads.

5.1.2 Objectives



- To analyze the events that led to the rise of Abbasids to power in 750 (CE).
- To discuss the various Abbasid caliphs and the land marks of their reigns.

5.1.3 Content



What immediate events followed the fall of the Umayyads?

With the declaration of the first Abbasid caliph, the remnants and the fugitives of the Umayyads were tracked down and annihilated one by one. Marwan II was killed on 5th August 750 in Egypt. The remains of the caliphs in Damascus and other places were exhumed by Abdallah - the uncle of the new caliph – and desecrated. The corpses were torn out and burnt with the single exception of the remains of Umar II whose tomb escaped this evil (desecration). Abdallah also treacherously executed 80 Umayyad princes. These princes had been invited to a banquet by the new caliph. Very few escaped the slaughter save for the young grandson of caliph Hisham called Abd al-Rahman ibn Muawiyya ibn Hisham who

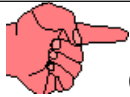
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escaped to Spain where he successfully established another Umayyad dynasty that ruled the Iberian peninsula for close to 300 years.

The Rise of the Abbasids.

With the fall of the Umayyads the glory of Syria passed away and its hegemony ended. The Arab period in the history of Islam ended and the Abbasids established a new era. The newly created capital Baghdad became the seat of the Abbasids.

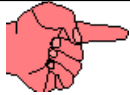
Note



On their ascension to power, the Abbasids proclaimed that they had brought a turn or change, a new order (era - *dawla*) in which the hierarchy of officers were drawn from the whole gamut of nationalities under the caliphate.

The Abbasid administration was to be based on the true principles of Muslim piety, religion and not race was to be the foundation of the state. The caliphs, in time, styled themselves as “shadows of God on earth”. They added titles which expressed moral or religious qualities e.g. *al-Mahdi* – the guided one; *al-Rashid* – the orthodox one; *al-Mu‘tamid* – he whose support is God; *al-Mutawakkil* – he who trusts in God.

Note



The establishment of the Abbasid caliphate destroyed the supremacy of the Arabs. The *Mawali*s were raised to a status of equality with the Arab Muslims. The army ceased to be dominated by the Arabs and became largely Persianized.

The founding of Baghdad reduced the power and influence of the cities of Basra and Kufa. But Islam and Arabic remained supreme. The success of the Persians was achieved within the ambit of Islam. The Abbasid reign lasted almost half a millennium: from the overthrow of the Umayyads in 750 till the destruction of Baghdad by the Mongols in 1258.

Abu al-Abbas (Al-Saffah) 750-754

He was the first Abbasid caliph who took the name al-Saffah (Blood Shedder). He became the founder of the most celebrated and longest-lived Arab dynasty in Islam after the Orthodox and Umayyad. Al-Saffah was not wholly recognized as caliph in Spain, North Africa, Oman, Sind and Khurasan. The *Alids* who had allied themselves to the Abbasids and who thought the latter were fighting the battle for them became disillusioned.

Al-Saffah died of small pox in 754 in his early thirties and was succeeded by his brother Abu Ja‘fer, (754-775) who took the title Al-Mansur (rendered victorious by God). Al-Mansur is regarded as one of the greatest Abbasid caliphs. He was the one who firmly established the Abbasid dynasty. All the 35 caliphs who came after him were his lineal descendants.

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Al-Mansur (754-775)

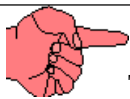
He consolidated the Muslim empire once more after the upheavals that followed the downfall of the Umayyads. In November 754, he defeated Abdallah bin al-Abbas, his uncle, who was the governor of Syria under the reign of Al-Saffah. Abdallah had disputed Al-Mansur's ascension to the caliphate. Later he turned to Abu Muslim, the Khorasanian leader who had spearheaded the uprising against the Umayyads. Abu Muslim who ruled Khorasan independently was treacherously put to death.

In 758, a revolt instigated by the Persian extremists (Rawandiyah) who tended to identify the caliph with God was quelled. A revolt by the Shi'ites headed by two great grandsons of Hasan, Muhammad and Ibrahim, was ruthlessly crushed. The two were killed in December 6th 762 and February 14th 763 respectively. On the other, the *Alids* became a thorn in the flesh of the Abbasids. To them, the Abbasids were usurpers. The legitimate caliphs and imams were supposed to be the descendants of Ali and Fatima. Between 767-768, a rebellion at Sunbad (Sinbadh) where the Magians wanted to avenge the death of Abu-Muslim, was ruthlessly crushed. In North Africa, the authority of Al-Mansur did not extend beyond Qairawan and Spain where Abd al-Rahman became a strong challenge.

In 762, Al-Mansur laid the foundation stone of his new capital Baghdad – probably signifying “gift of God”- which was built within a period of 4 years. Baghdad grew into a center of trade and commerce and a political center of international reputation. It later became the capital of the new Iraq Kingdom. Baghdad became an avenue for ideas from the Orient. With a lot of Persian influence, Persian titles, Persian wives, wines and mistresses; Persian songs, ideas and thoughts had an upper hand on Muslim life.

Under Al-Mansur was created the institution of *vizirate*. This was essentially a Persian office in an Islamic government. The first *vizier* (*wazir* – minister) was Khalid bin Barmuk who doubled as a Chief Minister and Counselor for the caliph. Khalid became a founder of an illustrious family of viziers whose influence and wealth was to make a mark on the entire political scene of the Abbasids. Al-Mansur died in October 7th 775 near Mecca while on a pilgrimage. However, his policies continued to guide his successors for many generations. He was succeeded by his son Al-Mahdi (775-785) who in turn was succeeded by Al-Hadi (785-786); then his brother, Harun al-Rashid (786-809); Al-Amin (809-813); his brother Al-Ma'mun (813-833); his brother Al-Mu'tasim (833-842); his son Al-Wathiq (842-847) and then Al-Mutawakkil (847-861).

Note



The Abbasid caliphate reached its peak between the reigns of the third caliph Al-Mahdi (775-785) and the ninth Al-Wathiq (842-848). This was especially during the reign of Harun al-Rashid (786-809) and that of his son Al-Mam'un (813-833).

Due to Harun al-Rashid and Al-Ma'mun, the Abbasid dynasty became the most celebrated in the annals of Islam. The decline started after Al-Wathiq (842-847) and continued until the reign of the 37th caliph Al-Muta'sim when the Mongols destroyed the empire in 1258 (CE).

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Al-Mahdi (775-785)

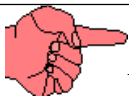
He was the first Abbasid caliph to resume expeditions against the Byzantines. Harun his future successor distinguished himself during these expeditions that made him to earn the honorific title al-Rashid (follower of the right path) from his father.

Harun al-Rashid (786-809)

The most brilliant period of the Abbasids is placed during the reign of Harun al-Rashid. During his reign, the Abbasid reign reached its peak. The country was prosperous and the court was characterised by lavish style of living where everything was plastered in gold. He left a remarkable history and his name became a legend for greatness and grandeur. He is the fiction hero of the Arabian Nights. According to Hitti (1973:302), during this period, Baghdad became a “city with no peer through out the whole world”. It had many annexes for harems, eunuchs and special functionaries. It was a great commercial centre and the greatest seat of learning and culture in the world.

When he ascended throne in 786, Harun appointed Yahya bin Khalid, his former teacher, as the vizier. The two sons of Yahya, Al-Fadl and Ja‘far practically ruled the empire for a period of almost 50 years.

Note



Under Harun al-Rashid, the Barmakids, as they were called, exercised a lot of influence and lived in a grand style. They amassed a lot of wealth and their munificence (great generosity) was felt in the financing the construction of canals, mosques and other works of public utility.

Al-Fadl was the first person in Islam to introduce the use of lamps in the mosques during Ramadhan. Ja‘far was renowned for his eloquence and penmanship (scholarship). As a result of these qualities Arab historians regard the Barmakids as the founders of a class designated as “people of the pen” (Ahl al-Qaram”). Ja‘far was a leader of fashions. The long neck that he possessed is said to have been responsible for the introduction of the custom of wearing high collars. Due to their high profile and the power that the Barmakids wielded, the caliph decided to end their tutelage (guardianship). Ja‘far was killed in 803. Yahya and three of his sons, including Al-Fadl were imprisoned. They died in prison and their property was confiscated, and this family which was founded by the first vizier Khalid bin Barmuk fell from grace never to rise again. Their fall also paved the way for the decline of the caliph’s rule in the Persian lands.

Al-Mamun (813-833)

He is rated as the one of the greatest Abbasid rulers. He promoted the study of various arts, philosophy and sciences. He encouraged philosophical discussions and favoured rationalism. He established libraries, observatories and other institutions. Many reputable scholars flourished in his court. He established the *Bayt al-Hikma* (House of Wisdom) that became one of the most important institutions of learning in the medieval period.

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5.1.4 Summary



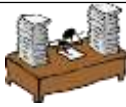
In this lesson we have analysed the rise of the Abbasids and the consolidation of Abbasid power by various rulers. Unlike the Umayyads who promoted the superiority of the Arab race, the Abbasids stressed on principles of religion and piety as opposed to race. It is evident that the Abbasid period witnessed a lot of Persian influence on Muslim life. Consequently, historians have described the coming to power of the Abbasids as the “victory of the Persians over the Arabs”.

5.1.5 Activities



- Analyse the rise of the Abbasids to power in 750 CE.
- “The Abbasid revolution was a victory of the Persians over the Arabs”. Comment

5.1.6 Further Reading



Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**, pp.195-260; 272-305
Hitti, P.K. 1973. **The History of the Arabs**, p.288
Lewis, B. 1993. **The Arabs in History**, pp. 84-106
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Shaban, M.A. 1979. **The Abbasid Revolution**. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, pp. 163-168

Lesson 5.2 Administration Under the Abbasids

5.2.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson, we analysed the rise of the Abbasids. In this lesson, we are going to examine the system of administration under the Abbasids and possibly compare and contrast it with that of the Umayyads (see Lesson 4.2).

5.2.2 Objectives



- To examine the system of administration of the Abbasids.
- To compare and contrast the Abbasid administration with that of the Umayyads.

5.2.3 Content

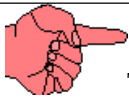


What were the features of Abbasid administration?

(a) The Abbasid administration's partition of the empire remained largely similar to that of the Umayyads. The empire was divided into provinces each administered by a governor and a superintendent of revenue, an agent of the caliph responsible for the collection and management of revenue and other administrative tasks. In most cases the governor was answerable to the *vizier* by whose recommendations he was appointed by the caliph. Among his duties were to direct the military affairs of the state, right of nomination and control of the judiciary, levying of taxes and maintenance of public security, safeguarding the state's religion against innovations, administration of police and presiding at public prayers on Friday.

(b) The Caliph was the head of state and the fountain - head of all power. He enjoyed absolute power and was the commander of the faithful. He could also lead in *Jumuah* and other congregational prayers. He was the leader of the army and the one who insured rule according to the Islamic law. He was to defend the state and ensure internal security.

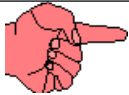
Note



The hereditary principle of succession to the caliphate that was established by the Umayyads continued to apply under the Abbasids.

This practice brought turmoil in the empire as the favoured or considered competent would-be-heirs to the throne were opposed and even usurpers came to the scene. For example the struggle between Al-Amin and Al-Mamun resulted in the death of the former. Al-Mamun's designation of his brother Al-Mutasim almost brought a revolt from his son who was side stepped.

Note



The Abbasid administration marked a departure from the Arab hegemony of the Umayyads to a broader egalitarian system in which the non-Arab Muslims especially the Persians played a more leading role.

(c) The highly structured Abbasid administration had several ministries: Treasury, Army, Intelligence etc. headed by the Chief Minister - the *Wazir* or *Vizier*- who was the head of the Cabinet. The office of the *vizier* ranked next to that of the caliph. Its work was to supervise the administrators and their staff. The *vizier* appointed and fired provincial governors. He also presided over the council whose members were the departmental heads.

(d) The judiciary was entrusted with the work of carrying out justice. This was perceived as religious duty to be carried out by the *Qadhi* or the Chief *Qadhi* who was to be a member of the *faqih* class (those learned in the Islamic law). The *faqih* decided cases, acted as a guardian for the orphans, lunatics and minors. He administered pious foundations, imposed punishment on those who violated the law; he appointed judicial deputies in the provinces.

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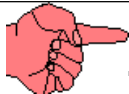
The police department was headed by a chief of police who could also double up as the as the royal bodyguard. There was a chief of Municipal Police who was an overseer of markets and morals. His duties were to oversee that proper weights and measures were used in trade and that legitimate morals were maintained. He ensured that social evils like gambling, usury and selling of wine were not committed.

(e) A Bureau of taxes continued to operate under the Abbasids. The sources of state revenue were *zakat*, *jizya*, *kharaj*, and tithes levied on goods owned by Muslims and those imported into the Muslim state. The tax system became more equitable under the Abbasids, since the Muslim Arabs and the non-Arab Muslims paid the same taxes. The revenue was used for the payment of troops, maintenance of mosques, roads, bridges, and for the general welfare of the community.

Al-Mahdi introduced an audit accounts office. There was also a board of correspondence or chancery office that handled all official letters, political documents, imperial mandates and diplomas-certificates of efficiency. There was a board for the inspection of grievances, a police department and a postal department. This board acted as a kind of a Court of Appeal or Supreme Court to look into the misuse of justice in the administrative and political departments. This institution which was introduced by the Umayyads was revived by Al-Mahdi and continued to operate under Al-Hadi, Harun al-Rashid, Al-Mamun and Al-Muhtadi (869-870).

Militarily, no large standing army was maintained. There were the caliphal bodyguards who were almost the regular troops. There were soldiers referred to as the regulars, mercenaries, adventurers and volunteers.

(f) During the Abbasid caliphate the Arab hegemony was broken. Polygamy, concubinage and slavery and slave trade the avenues of the fusion of Arabian blood with that of the subject peoples. As a result, Arabian social organisation broke down.



The purity of the Arab race was diluted through intermarriages with non-Arabs and non-Muslims and slaves.

Among the Abbasid caliphs for example, only three were sons of free mothers viz: Abu-al-Abbas, Al-Mahdi and Al-Amin. Al-Mansur's mother was a Berber slave while that of Al-Mamun was a Persian slave. Al-Wathiq's and Al-Muhtadi's were Greek while Al-Muntansir's was Greco-Abyssinian etc.

Like during the Umayyad era, *Dhimmi*s continued to enjoy religious toleration: they preserved their own languages and religion. They held some important financial, clerical and professional positions in spite of some discriminative legislations enacted against them. For example Harun ar-Rashid in 807 decreed that all churches in the borderlands should be demolished. At times, *dhimmi*s were ordered to wear special clothes.

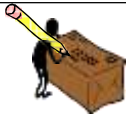
Slaves were the servants who were captured by force, prisoners of war or purchased in the time of peace. Among them were Negroes, Turks, Greeks, Slavs, Armenians and Berbers. Some slaves served as eunuchs attached to harems.

5.2.4 Summary



This lesson has examined the system of administration under the Abbasids. It is observed that the Abbasid state was a Muslim state rather than an Arab state where all Muslims enjoyed equal privileges. The Arab hegemony that was supreme under the Umayyads was broken and the Abbasids established a more egalitarian society. Most significantly, the Abbasid administration was a departure from the Umayyads in respect to the *Mawalis* who enjoyed a better status. The Abbasid state had a religious character. On the other hand, the Abbasid administration remained largely similar to that of the Umayyads in that, while the Umayyad acted as Arab chiefs, their Abbasid counterparts acted as kings and established courts in the pattern of Persian emperors. Hence the Persian influence in the Abbasid administration was evident in such offices as those of the Wazir.

5.2.5 Activities



- Discuss the system of administration of the Abbasids and compare it with that of the Umayyads.
- “The position of the *Mawalis* did not change appreciably during the Abbasid dynasty”. Discuss.

5.2.6 Further Reading



Esposito, J.L. 1984. **Islam and Politics**, pp.16-20
Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**: pp.261-263
Hitti, P.K. 1973. **The History of the Arabs**. London: Macmillan, p.317
Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, pp. 83-91
Watt, W.M. 1968. **What is Islam?** Longmans: Librairie du Liban, pp.121-130

Lesson 5.3 Major Achievements under the Abbasids

5.3.1 Introduction

Having looked at the administration under the Abbasids, we now focus attention to the achievements of the Abbasids. The Abbasid Dynasty lasted for over half a millenia, from 750-1258. It was the longest-lived dynasties of Islamic history. For a dynasty that ruled for so many years, there must have been some important contributions that could be attributed to the dynasty.

5.3.2 Objective



To identify and assess the achievements of the Abbasid dynasty.

5.3.3 Content



What were the main achievements of the Abbasids?

(a) Development of Islamic Law

The Abbasids gave a lot of support to the development of the *shariah*. That became their most significant contribution to Islam. The work of the early law schools that began during the late Umayyad period flourished under the caliph's patronage of religious scholars. The first two centuries of Abbasid rule (750-950) witnessed the establishment of various schools of law in the major centers of the empire. In these centers Islamic law had been finalized and institutionalized.

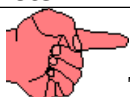
(b) Development of Islamic Culture and Civilization

The Abbasid period also witnessed the development of Islamic culture and civilization. The Abbasids were committed patrons of culture and arts. They developed law, religious disciplines such as Qur'an interpretation, tradition, criticism, history and biography. The process of Arabicization that started during the late Umayyad period was completed by the end of the 9th century (CE). Arabic language replaced Syriac, Coptic, Aramaic and Greek. Arabic became the language of communication in intellectual debates, government and literature.

(c) Intellectual Awakening

The Abbasid caliphate witnessed the most tremendous intellectual awakening in the history of Islam. This awakening was brought about by the foreign influences especially those from Greece, India, Persia and Syria. Consequently, translation bureaus were established. Manuscripts were obtained from the farthest corners of the empire and translated from their original languages such as Greek, Syriac, Latin, Sanskrit, and Persian into Arabic.

Note



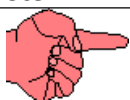
These translations brought the best of literature and sciences into the domain of the Muslim. Muslim intellectual and artistic growth followed the period of translation and assimilation.

In three quarters of a century after the establishment of the Abbasid caliphate, significant contributions were made in the fields of literature and philosophy; art and architecture; science, medicine and mathematics. The Muslims had gained the possessions of the chief philosophical works of Aristotle, the leading Neoplatonic commentators and the most of the medical writings of Galen, Ptolemy and Hippocrates, as well as Persian and Indian scientific works. Translation of Greek works began under Al-Ma'mun and continued under his immediate successors. During the reign of Al-Mansur, Indian and Persian works on astronomy were translated into Arabic. The Islamic dimension was added to the study of astronomy in which the direction of prayer (*qibla*) was fixed.

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Note



Arabic numerals also came into being through the influence of mathematics from India. This was accompanied by the development of the decimal system.

(d) Development of Culture and Culture Centers

The cultural and intellectual domination of Islam during the Abbasids prompted the Arab historians to refer to this period as the golden age of Islamic civilization. The main urban (cultural) centers of this civilization included Cordova in Spain, Baghdad, Cairo, Nishapur and Palermo. These centers eclipsed Christian Europe that was still mired in the Dark Ages. Hellenism was one of the most important foreign influences in Muslim life. The peak of this influence came during the reign of Al-Ma'mun under whom the *Mutazilite* doctrines flourished. He delighted in intellectual debates and made pronouncements in favour of the doctrine of the created-ness of the Qur'an. In 827, Al-Ma'mun imposed an inquisition (*mihna*) in which all judges, government officials and teachers were supposed or required to subscribe to the doctrine of the created-ness of the Qur'an. This inquisition was maintained during the reigns of Al-Mu'tasim and Al-Wathiq but was abolished by Al-Mutawakkil in 842 when the Qur'an was finally declared to be uncreated.

(e) Development of House of Wisdom (*Bayt al-Hikma*)

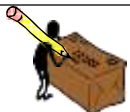
In 830 Caliph Al-Ma'mun established the House of Wisdom (**Bayt al-Hikma**) in Baghdad. This was a combination of a library, academy and a translation bureau that proved to be a very important educational institution since the foundation of Alexandrian Museum in the first half of the third century.

5.3.4 Summary



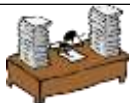
This lesson has identified and assessed the main achievements of the Abbasid dynasty. These were: development of Islamic law; development of Islamic culture and civilization; intellectual awakening; development of culture and culture centres and establishment of the House of Wisdom. Due to these achievements, historians consider the Abbasid Dynasty as the “golden age” in the annals of the Arabs and Islam.

5.3.5 Activities



- “The golden age of Islam should be attributed to the Abbasid period”. Discuss.
- How did the Abbasid caliphs help to nurture the great Muslim civilization?

5.3.6 Further Reading



Esposito, J.L. 1984. **Islam and Politics**.
Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**
Hitti, P.K. 1973. **The History of the Arabs**. London: Macmillan., pp. 241-262
Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, pp. 91-97

Lesson 5.4 Decline and Fall of the Abbasids

5.4.1 Introduction

As mentioned in the previous lesson, the Abbasid period was the longest-lived dynasty of Islamic history. The Abbasid period in the history of Islam may be divided into two periods viz: the early period from 750-945 CE, that is approximately 195 years. The second is the later period from 945-1258 CE, a period of 313 years. The year 945 is the turning point because this is the year the Shi'a Buwayhids captured power and left the Abbasids as mere nominal rulers. The entire Abbasid period produced 37 caliphs, out of which only four were capable and great. These were: Al-Mansur, Al-Mahdi, Harun al-Rashid and Mamun. The rest were inept and political mediocres. This lesson highlights the decline and fall of the Abbasids that started from the later Abbasid period.

5.4.2 Objectives



- Trace the events that led to the fall of the Abbasid dynasty
- Discuss the factors that contributed to the fall of the Abbasids

5.4.3 Content

The Abbasid political unity began to deteriorate drastically after 950. From 861 to 945, there were religious and regional differences among the Shi'ites and the Kharajites, and competition for political ascendancy that ultimately led to a series of revolts and secessionist movements. However disintegration started as early as 800 when Tunisia and Morocco became self-autonomous and established their own dynasties. They only gave nominal allegiance to the Government at Baghdad through the payment of tribute.

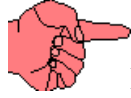
Before that, the Alids who felt cheated by the Abbasids expressed their annoyance through unsuccessful uprisings. For example there was a revolt in Medina in 762. Muhammad ibn Abdullah a great grandson of Hassan, Ali's elder son, headed the revolt. The Abbasid caliph al-Mansur, killed him and his brother Idris, fled to North Africa where he later founded an independent Alid principality in Morocco. There was another unsuccessful revolt in Mecca in 786. In 791, descendants of Hassan's son Zayd founded the Zaydite dynasty. In about 864, Harun al-Rashid, suppressed another revolt by the Alids. Al-Mamun, his son, had to quell two revolts, one in Iraq and the other in Mecca. In 851, Caliph al-Mutawakkil destroyed the shrine of Hussein at Kerbala and prohibited pilgrimages to the shrine. At the end of the 9th century, the Alid upsurge came in form of Ismailism uprising. But they failed to dethrone the Abbasids. However they kept the empire in a state of disturbances until its final disintegration.

Caliph al-Mamun (813-833) was a politically inept caliph who lost the grip of Khurasan - the eastern province. Ultimately a Persian principality was established there in 820. Mutasim (833-842) surrounded himself with Turkish bodyguards whose luxuries provoked discontents at Baghdad. A mutiny during the reign of al-Mutawakkil (846-862) by his Turkish bodyguards led to his death. This episode was followed by 10 years of political anarchy in which one caliph after the other who ascended the throne was killed. During this turmoil, a Persian part of the caliphate seceded. A Turkish mercenary Ahmad bin Tulun declared himself master of Egypt and Syria, while a slave revolt broke out in Basra and spread to lower Iraq.

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Caliph Muktafi (902-907) was the last able Abbasid ruler who recovered Egypt from the Tulunids. After him, decline proceeded.

Note



Between 909-1171, a rival dynasty was established in Egypt by the Fatimids to challenge the supremacy of the Abbasids.

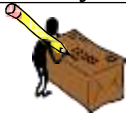
In Iran, Syria and Iraq, local governors asserted their independence as leaders of semi-autonomous states. By the reign of Caliph Al-Radi (934-940), the vestiges of whatever dignity and prestige that had remained of the Abbasid Caliphate disappeared. Once a mighty Empire, the Abbasid was by then a ghost of its former self. By 945, the disintegration of the unified Abbasid caliphate became apparent when the Buwayhids who ruled several semi-autonomous states in western Iran invaded Baghdad and seized power. The Buwayhids who were Shi'ites (Shi'a) only left the Caliph as the nominal head of the empire. The Abbasids were only symbols of a legitimate government. The real power and authority was vested in various military dynasties such as the Buwayhid and the Turkic (Seljuq). Finally in 1258, the Mongols swept across central Asia, conquered Persia and set upon Baghdad which they captured and killed the caliph al-Mustasim. This led to the downfall (end) of the Abbasid caliphate.

5.4.2 Summary



In this lesson we have attempted to highlight the events and factors that led to the decline and eventual fall of the Abbasids. It is shown that political disintegration of the Abbasid Empire proceeded apace and was aided by the caliphs' inability to pacify the various disenchanted groups like the Kharijites, the Turks (Seljuqs) and the Shi'ites. It is these groups that kept the empire on its toes as they established quasi-autonomous states that weakened the foundation of the Abbasid power.

5.4.3 Activity



Trace and highlight the events that contributed to the fall of the Abbasid dynasty.

5.4.4 Further Reading



Hasan, M. 1998. **History of Islam, Vol. 1**, pp.264-271; 306-311
Hitti, P.K. 1973. **The History of the Arabs**.
Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, p.126-136
Saunders, J.J. 1965. **A History of Medieval Islam**, pp.104-111.

LECTURE 6 RELIGIO-POLITICAL DIVISIONS AND THE DEVELOPMENT OF SECTARIANISM IN ISLAM

Lesson 6.1 The Division Between Sunni and Shia

6.1.1 Introduction

In this lesson, we will look at the religio-political divisions in Islam that split the community into Sunni and Shi'a. Many of the issues examined in this lesson and other lessons that follow in this lecture are briefly mentioned in lectures 2 and 4. We should bear in mind from the beginning that the divisions that came up pitting the Shi'a against the Sunni were based on the issue of the caliphate that was essentially a political office that came into existence after the death of the Prophet.

6.1.2 Objectives



- To trace the origin of the division between the Sunni and the Shi'a and account for the development of sectarianism in Islam.
- To compare the Sunni concept of leadership with that of the Shi'a.

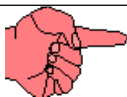
6.1.3 Content



How did the division between the Sunni and Shi'a come about?

According to Jafri, in his book, **Origins and Early Development of Shi'a Islam**, in the early years of the development of the history of Islam, one may not talk of the orthodox Sunni and the heretical Shi'a. As a designation for the followers of Ali, and the people of his house, hence a distinct sect within Islam, the term Shi'a was a later stage. According to Tabatabai, in his book **Shi'a**, the term Shi'a began to be used with a reference made for the first time to the partisans of Ali, the first leader of the house of the Prophet.

Note



The divisions that came up in Islam after the death of the Prophet in 632 were religio-political.

The Prophet did not designate his successor. The selection of Abu Bakr to lead the community (as a caliph) by the *Ansar* and the *Muhajirun* was based on the fact that, the Prophet had nominated him to lead prayers during his illness, hence they justified that the Prophet could have preferred Abu Bakr as his caliph. This is a Sunnite view. However the supporters of Ali held the view that the caliphate and religious authority after the death of the Prophet belonged to Ali. This Shi'a view was reinforced by Ali's position and station to life in relation to the Prophet, and being one of the closest companions of the Prophet. According to the Shi'a, many times, the Prophet seemed to have favoured Ali for the caliphate. During the farewell pilgrimage, the Prophet seemed to have implied this when he said: "Ali is to me what Aaron was to Moses, Almighty God, be a friend to his friends and an enemy to his enemies, help those who help him and frustrate the hopes of those who betray him". The Shiite view also holds that the Prophet had clearly asserted that Ali was preserved from error and sin in his actions and sayings.

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Whatever he said and did was in perfect conformity with the teachings of Islam. Ali was the most knowledgeable of men in matters pertaining to the Islamic sciences and injunctions.

According to the Shi'a, the selection of Abu Bakr as a caliph without a prior consultation of the Household of the Prophet, his relatives and friends infuriated Ali and his friends who protested against the act of choosing the caliph by consultation or election and also against those who were behind that action. According to Tabatabai, this protest and criticism is the one that separated from the majority, the minority that were following Ali, and made his followers known to society as the "partisans" or "*shi'a*" of Ali. Majority of the Muslims supported the caliphate as a principle of consensus (*ijma*) of the community. They were the Sunni.

From the beginning *Shi'at Ali* (partisans of Ali) consisted only of a small personal following who regarded Ali as the legitimate and most worthy person to the office of the caliph who could have led the Muslims after the death of the Prophet. Due to the fragile nature of the community, the expression of Shi'a was guarded in order not to divide the community into sections comprised of the majority and the minority. Shi'ism was hence condemned and it could not achieve much. Ali acquiesced in the political atmosphere of the day. He lacked sufficient political and military might to rebel against the political order of the day. Silently however, his partisans held the view that to Ali belonged religious authority and the right to succession to the Prophet; and that spiritual or religious matters should be referred to him. They therefore invited people to become his followers.

The Question of Leadership

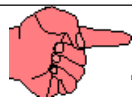
Under Muawiyya as the caliph, a theory was formulated that it was in the interest of the state and aspects of the community that should be followed to decide the question of leadership of the community.



What were the qualifications for leadership?

The qualifications for leadership were personal power and strength, ability to defend the Muslims and rule the subjects effectively. Majority of the Muslims placed the religious leadership in totality of the community represented by the *ulama* (scholars) as the custodians of religion and exponents of the Qur'an and the *sunna* of the Prophet. They also accepted state authority as a binding factor.

Note



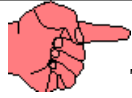
The majority became commonly referred to as the Sunnis.

The minority on the other hand repudiated the authority of the people to elect a spiritual head. Since the spiritual head should be a heritage bequeathed by Muhammad to Ali and his descendants. This minority (Shiites) could get satisfaction for their religious aspirations from the leadership of the *Ahl al-Bayt* (Household of the Prophet). This minority had to accept state's authority, but the sole exponents of the Qur'an and the *sunna* are the people from the household of the Prophet.

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Note



This minority became known as the Shiites.

According to the Shiites, the imamate descends by divine appointment in the apostolic line. The imam should be a descendant of the Prophet, must possess certain qualities, he must be a *masum* (sinless), bear the purest and most unsullied or untainted reputation and character and should be distinguished above all other men for truth and purity because as the Shi'ites argue, human choice is fallible. They argue that if the choice of the imam is left to the community, it will subvert morality and spiritual guidance.

According to the Sunnis, the imamate is not to be restricted to the house of the Prophet and his family. The imam need not be just, virtuous or irreproachable (*masum*) in his life, nor does he need to be the most eminent or excellent person of his time, so long as he is free, an adult, sane and possessed of capacity to attend to the ordinary affairs of the state, he is qualified for election. The Sunnis hold the view that, the imamate is indivisible and that it is not lawful to have two imams at one and the same time. The imam is the patron and a syndic (member of the committee) of all Muslims; he is the guardian of their interests. He is vested with the power to nominate his successors subject to the approval of the Muslims. The nomination is dependent on the choice of the people as the office is for temporal benefit and the spiritual benefit of the community.

6.1.4 Summary



In this lesson, we have traced the events that led to the divisions between the Sunni and the Shi'a. It is noted that those divisions stemmed from the issue of the caliphate that was largely a political office. Hence it could be concluded that the divisions between the Sunni and the Shi'a are religio-political. As a result of these divisions, both Sunni and Shi'a evolved a conception of leadership of the community.

6.1.5 Key Words



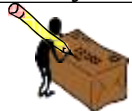
Ahl al-bayt: the household of the Prophet

Masum: sinless, infallibility; a quality that is attributed to the Shi'a imams

Shi'a: literally, partisans; the various groups united by the belief that Ali, the prophet's nephew and son-in-law and his descendants were divinely appointed to lead the Muslim community, politically and spiritually

Sunni: those who consider themselves followers of the authentic sunna – followers of mainstream or orthodox Islam as opposed to the Shi'a and other sects

6.1.6 Activity



Discuss the main differences between the Sunni and the Shi'a

6.1.7 Further Reading



Ali, A. 1974. **The Spirit of Islam**. London: Chatto & Windus, p. 314
Jafri, S.H.M. 1979. **Origins and Early Development of Shi'a Islam**. London: Longman, pp. 92-100
Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, pp.115-120, 163-164
Tabatabai, A.S.M.H. 1981. **Shi'a**. Qum: Ansariyan Publications, pp.39-61
Watt, W.M. 1968. **What is Islam?** Longmans: Librairie du Liban, pp.113-121

Lesson 6.2 Developments in the Sunni and Shia Divide

6.2.1 Introduction

Although there existed divisions between the partisans of Ali and the rest of the community, in the period following the death of the Prophet and that of the four rightly guided caliphs, we cannot talk of the Shi'a as a sect. In any case, it is already noted (see Lesson 2.5) that the Kharajites were the first sect in Islam. This lesson therefore analyses the various events between the partisans of Ali and the rest of the Muslim community that culminated into the formation of the Shi'a as a sect and the consolidation of the Shi'a identity. The lesson further shows how the Shi'a was thrown into a situation of sectarianism due to the issue of leadership. This resulted into various Shi'a sects.

6.2.2 Objectives

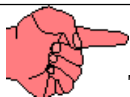


- To account for the developments leading to the emergence of the Shi'a as sect
- To show the emergence of various Shi'a sects

6.2.3 Content

The succession of Ali to the caliphate in 656 was contested by a number of companions of the Prophet including Talha, Zubair and Ayesha. This eventually led to the Battle of the Camel that marked the first *Fitna* (civil war) in Islam.

Note



The Battle of the Camel brought a serious rift in the Muslim community. After this battle, the term *Shi'at Ali* came to include all those who had supported Ali against Ayesha, Zubair and Talha.

During the caliphate of Ali, Shi'ism did not display any open hostility or opposition to the rest of the Muslim society. Shiites even fought alongside the Sunni majority in holy wars and participated in public activities. Ali guided the Sunni majority in the interest of the whole Muslim community of Muslims whenever such action was necessary. Ali is considered the first imam of the Shi'a.

Ali was assassinated in 661, and Hasan his son became the second imam of the Shia. But Muawiyya who had waged war against Ali continued to wage war. Through intrigues and payment of great sums of

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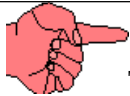
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money, Muawiyya corrupted the aides and generals of Hasan who was forced to abdicate in favour of Muawiyya to avoid further bloodshed and to make peace. He handed the caliphate to Muawiyya on condition that the caliphate would be returned to him after the death of Muawiyya and that no harm would be done to his followers. But Muawiyya never honoured this promise as went ahead and nominated his son Yazid as the heir-apparent, thereby establishing a dynasty. Hasan later died of food poisoning in 669 A.D. Muawiyya also ordered the cursing of Ali from the pulpit of mosques throughout the empire, a practice that continued under the Umayyad caliphs until the reign of Umar II when it was discontinued.

With the abdication of Hasan, he prevented a bloody conflict with Muawiyya. But this abdication did not heal the split in the community. In deed Hasan's abdication had far reaching consequences for the later development of Shi'ism. The followers of Muawiyya became the central body while the Shi'at Ali was reduced to the role of a small opposition that was thrust into sectarian position.

After the death of Muawiyya in 680, Yazid became the caliph. However the Shiites who wanted Hussein, Ali's youngest son to ascend the throne contested the caliphate of Yazid. The resultant conflicts between Yazid and Hussein led to the martyrdom of Hussein and his forces at Kerbala. The death of Hussein according to Jafri (1979): "set the seal" of an official Shi'ism. The martyrdom played a great role in the consolidation of the Shi'a identity. It became the most effective agent in the propagation and comparatively rapid spread of Shi'ism especially in the regions away from the centre of the caliphate such as Yemen and Persia.

Note



The tragedy of Kerbala added to the Shia Islam an element of passion that became a characteristic feature of the Shia. The tragedy further penitents who let themselves die as a way of repenting for their failure to fulfil their commitments to the grandson of the Prophet.

The martyrdom further provided a ground from which Mukhtar- the self-acclaimed ambassador of Muhammad ibn Hanifaya- was to launch his movement. It provided an effective slogan to the Abbasids for overthrowing the Umayyad dynasty. Ultimately, the name and memory of Husein became an inseparable part of the Shiite moral and religious fervour.

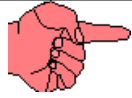
During the imamate of Husein, the third imam, Shiites remained united; since he was the only head and imam of the house of the Prophet. But with his sudden death and the acquiescence of his only surviving son- Zayn al- Abidin left the Shiites in state of confusion and this created a leadership vacuum. Zayn al- Abidin who was 23 years old survived the massacre of Kerbala since he did not take part in fighting as he was sick at the time. Thereafter, he lived in Medina and he did not involve himself in any politics whatsoever.

The period after Husein's death marked the first conflict over the leadership of the followers of Ali. This resulted in the division of the Shia into various sects. After the death of Husein, majority of the Shia followed his son Zayn al-Abidin as the fourth imam. A minority followed Muhammad ibn Hanafiya as the fourth imam as well as the promised Mahdi. After the death of Al-Abidin, majority followed his son, Muhammad al-Baqir while a minority followed Zayd al-Shahid son of Zayn al Abidin.

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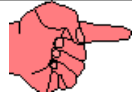
Note



These followers became known as the Zaydians.

The followers of Al-Baqir accepted his son Jafar as-Sadiq as the 6th imam. After the death of Jafar, the majority followed his son Musa al Kazim as the 7th imam while another group followed an elder son of Jafar, Ismael, who had predeceased his father. It is also argued that Jafar disinherited his elder son because of the latter's love for drink. Some denied the right to Jafar to alter the succession, and declared Ismael not to be dead but hidden and recognised him as the 7th imam.

Note



The followers of Ismael became known as the Seveners or the Ismailis.

Another group stopped with the 6th imam and considered him the last imam. After the death of imam Musa al-Kazim, majority followed his son Ali al-Rida as the 8th imam. Some stopped with the 7th imam. Most of the small sects dissolved themselves within a short time. From the 8th imam to the 12th one, there was no schism in Shiism. The 12th imam is believed to be the Promised Mahdi.

6.2.4 Summary



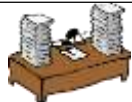
In this lesson, we have analysed the events that led to the formation of the Shi'a as a sect following the death of Caliph Ali and the consolidation of the Shi'a identity. It is apparent that the issue of leadership among the Shi'a brought further sectarianism that culminated into other sects such as the Zaydians and Ismailis.

6.2.5 Activity



Account for the growth of schism within Islam

6.2.6 Further Reading



Al-Kashifu'l-ghita, A.S.M.H. 1993. **The Origin of Shi'ite Islam and its Principles**. Qum: Ansariyan Publications, pp.25-40

Ali, A. 1974. **The Spirit of Islam**, p. 314

Jafri, S.H.M. 1979. **Origins and Early Development of Shi'a Islam**.

Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, pp.115-120; 163-164

Tabatabai, A.S.M.H. 1981. **Shi'a**. pp. 63-67

Watt, W.M. 1968. **What is Islam?**, pp.113-121

Lesson 6.3 Some of the Main Shia Sects

6.3.1 Introduction

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In the previous lesson, it became obvious that one cannot talk of a homogenous Shi'a sect. As it were, the Shi'a is a heterogeneous group with many subsects. The various Shi'a subsects are known and identified by their various names. This lesson examines some of the main Shi'a sects.

6.3.2 Objectives



- To identify and examine some of the main Shi'a sects
- To examine the beliefs and teachings of some of the sects identified above.

6.3.3 Content



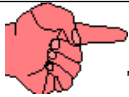
Which are some of the main Shi'a sects?

Some of the main Shi'a sects are, but not limited to the following:

(a) The Twelvers

They are also referred to as the Ithna' Asheris or the Imamis. They are so called because they accept the leadership of the 12 imams.

Note



The Twelvers form the majority of the Shi'ites, from among the Zaydians, Ismailis and others who seceded from them.

They hold the belief that the imamate descended by express appointment in the following order (1) Ali (2) Hasan (3) Husayn (4) Ali ibn Husayn [Zayn al-Abidin] (5) Muhammad al-Baqir (6) Jafar as-Sadiq (7) Musa al-Kazim (8) Ali ibn Musa [al-Rida] (9) Muhammad Ali-Taqi (10) Muhammad Naqi (11) Ali al-Askari (12) Muhammad al-Mahdi who was the last imam and who according to the Shia belief disappeared in the 5th year of his age. He is believed to be still alive, and the Twelvers look forward with earnest anticipation to his reappearance to re-establish the purity of the human race.

According to the Twelvers, the Islamic caliphate of which esoteric guidance and spiritual leadership are inseparable elements, belong to Ali and his descendants. The injunctions and regulations of the sharia that are enshrined in the Qur'an must be learned through the guidance of the household of the Prophet. The Twelvers follow the jurisprudence of the household of the Prophet, and Muhammad is the seal of the Prophets. They hold the belief that the Prophet had 12 successors and that the Qur'an has an exoteric and esoteric aspect.

(b) The Zaydians

They are the followers of Zayd al-Shahid son of Zayn al-Abidin who is also referred to as Ali al-Sajjad. The Zaydians believe that Zayd is the 5th imam, after Ali, Hasan, Husayn, Ali al-Abidin and then Zayd. According to Zaydism, the people have a right of choosing their imam or spiritual head from among the descendants of the Prophet provided that person is learned in the religious sciences, ethically pure, courageous and generous. They therefore combine the principle of election with the principle that

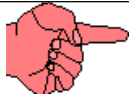
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restricts the imamate to the *Ahl al-Bayt*. They hold the belief that it is lawful to elect the less eminent (distinguished) while the most eminent is present. As a result of this principle, they at the beginning considered the first two caliphs - Abu Bakr and Umar - as their imams. As a result of this acceptance, other Shiites referred to them as dissenters. Later the names of the first two caliphs were deleted from the list of imams.

The Zaydians do not limit the number of their imams to 12. They hold the belief that, in addition to piety, truth, knowledge and innocence or sinless as the qualities for the office of the imam, an imam should possess bravery and the capacity to assert by force of arms his right to the imamate. They do not use the jurisprudence of the house of the Prophet.

Note



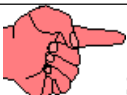
The Zaydians are divided into various sub-sects or subsections differing from each other about the devolution of the imamate from the grandson of Zayd.

Zayd was succeeded by Yahya ibn Zayd who in turn was succeeded by Muhammad ibn Abdallah who in turn was succeeded by Ibrahim ibn Abdallah. The three were the chosen imams before they were killed in a revolt during the Abbasid period.

(c) The Ismailis

They are also referred to as the Seveners a name they derive from Ismail, son of Jafar as-Sadiq, who they recognise as the 7th h imam instead of Musa al-Kazim. Ismail died before his father. At his deathbed, his father Jafar summoned witnesses including the governor of Medina. The followers believe that Ismail did not die but went into occultation; that he would appear again as the Promised Mahdi. They also believe that the summoning of witnesses by Jafar was meant to hide the truth in fear of al-Mansur, the Abbasid caliph. Another group believed that the true imam was Ismail whose death meant that the imamate was transferred to his son Muhammad. A third group believed that although Ismail died during the life time of his father, he was the imam and therefore the imamate passed to his son Muhammad ibn Ismail and his descendants. The first two groups became extinct while the belief of the third one held sway. This is the group that continued to exist though it underwent various sectarian divisions in the development of Ismailism.

Note



Sectarianism within Ismailism centred on the legitimacy of imam and it led to the rise of such groups as Batinis, Nazarīs - who are today led by the Aga Khan as the spiritual head - the Mustaris - who are today survived by the Bhoras; and the Druzes who live in Syria and Lebanon.

According to the Ismailis, the earth cannot exist without proof (*hujja*) of God. The proof is in form of a "speaker" and "silent one". The speaker is a prophet and the silent one is an imam (guardian) who is an inheritor or executor of the testament of a prophet. The principle of the proof of God revolves constantly around the number 7. A prophet is a manifestation of God. His function is to bring a divine message or sharia to the people through prophesy. A prophet can also initiate people into the divine mysteries. After

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the prophet, there are 7 executors or imams who carry out the testament of the prophet. The 7th imam in succession possesses the power to carry out or execute the testament of the prophet and the power of esoteric initiation into the divine mysteries. The cycle of imams is then repeated with the 7th prophet. Adam's 7th executor was Noah; Abraham was Noah's 7th executor; Moses was the 7th executor of Abraham; Jesus was the 7th executor of Moses; Muhammad was the 7th executor of Jesus and Muhammad ibn Ismail was the 7th executor of Muhammad. The executors of the Prophet are Ali, Husayn, Zayn al- Abidin, Muhammad al-Baqir, Jafar as-Sadiq, and Muhammad ibn Ismail. Then, follows seven descendants of Ismail whose names were hidden and secret, followed by the first seven rulers of the Fatimid caliphate in Egypt.

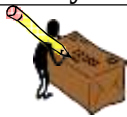
For the Ismailis, the prophesy does not end with the Prophet Muhammad. They also allow change and transformation in the injunctions of the *shariah* (and even among the Batinis, rejection of duty following the *sharia*).

6.3.4 Summary



This lesson has identified three main Shi'a sub-sects and examined some of their beliefs and teachings. These sub-sects are: Twelvers, Zaydians and Ismailis. Evidently, schism within Shi'ism (Shi'a sects) emerged due to the question of leadership. In the course of their evolution, many of the other Shi'a sub-sects, save the Twelvers, split further into other sub-sects. Ideally, although the term Shi'a refers to a conglomeration of sub-sects, it has become synonymous with the Twelvers.

6.3.5 Activity



Identify the various Shi'a sub-sects and examine their teachings.

6.3.6 Further Reading



Al-Kashifu'l-ghita, A.S.M.H. 1993. **The Origin of Shi'ite Islam and its Principles**, pp.41-102

Ali, A. 1974. **The Spirit of Islam**. London:

Jafri, S.H.M. 1979. **Origins and Early Development of Shi'a Islam**, pp. 92-100, 211

Tabatabai, A.S.M.H. 1981. **Shi'a**. pp. 75-85

Tritton, A.S. **Islam: Belief and Practices**. London: Hutchinson University Library, pp.72-

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Lesson 6.4: The Shi'a Doctrine of the Imamate

6.4.1 Introduction

This lesson examines the Shi'a doctrine of the imamate. This is a cardinal doctrine of the Shi'a Ithna'Asheris and as such does not necessarily apply to the other sub-sects of the Shi'a. It shown that the doctrine that is central to the Shi'a faith revolves around the two principles of *nass* and *'ilm*.

6.4.2 Objectives



- To examine the foundation of the Shi'a doctrine of the imamate.
- To discuss the two fundamental principles underlying this doctrine.

6.4.3 Content



What are the foundations of the doctrine of imamate?

The foundation of the concept of the doctrine of imamate with its spiritual and religious function, was laid down by Zayn al-Abidin, and Muhammad al-Baqir the fourth and fifth imams of the Shi'a Ithna 'Asheris respectively. However, this doctrine was elucidated and elaborated by Ja'far as-Sadiq the sixth imam.

Jafar, the sixth imam and the eldest son of Muhammad al-Baqir was born around 80 AH (699-700 CE) or 83 AH (703-704 CE). He was renowned for religious learning; and his name in regard to this was greater than that of his father Al-Baqir, or of any other Twelver imam except for Ali, the fourth orthodox caliph. Jafar's imamate witnessed the most crucial period of Islamic history both in political and doctrinal spheres. He was a contemporary of Malik bin Anas and Abu Hanifa who busied themselves with the study and systematisation of the *sharia* through *Fiqh* (Islamic jurisprudence). As a descendant of the Prophet, Jafar was known for his and the family's learning in religious matters. The Shia looked upon him as an imam of *Fiqh* just like the way the Sunni looked upon Malik and Abu Hanifa.

In the doctrine of the imamate, Jafar emphasized on two fundamental principles:



What is the first fundamental principle of the doctrine and what does it entail?

(a) The principle of *Nass*.

According to this principle, the imamate is a prerogative bestowed by God on a chosen person from the family of the Prophet. Before the death of the chosen person, and with God's guidance, the imam transfers the imamate to another by explicit designation (*nass*). On the authority of *nass*, the imamate is confined to a definite individual among all the descendants of Ali and Fatima. The transfer of the imamate through *nass* would be incomplete and meaningless unless it is traced back to Ali who should have been entrusted with the office of the imamate by the Prophet himself. The *nass* initiated by the Prophet came down from Ali to Hasan, from Hasan to Hussein up to Jafar through successive *nass*.

The principle of *nass* was reinforced by the emphasis of Ali's rights to spiritual leadership of the community as the divinely favoured legatee of the Prophet. The successors of Ali, that is Hasan, Hussein, Zayn al-Abidin and Muhammad al-Baqir, never failed to propound Ali's rights and superiority to the heritage of the Prophet. Jafar cited many verses of the Qur'an especially the *mutashabihat* - verses that require interpretation as opposed to *muhkamat* (clear unambiguous) verses - to propound those rights. By virtue of his birth and family background, Jafar could lay claims to explain or interpret the Qur'an than other Muslims who only acquired their knowledge through scholarship.

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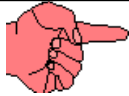


What is the second fundamental principle and what does it entail?

(b) The principle of *'ilm*.

This means that an imam is a divinely inspired possessor of a special sum of knowledge of religion that can only be passed on before his death to the following imam. An imam of the time is the exclusive authoritative source of knowledge in religious matters. Without his guidance no one can follow the right path. This special knowledge includes the external (*zahir*) and the esoteric (*batin*) meanings of the Qur'an.

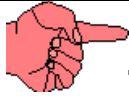
Note



'Ilm the special sum of knowledge of religion which Jafar declared for himself should also be traced back to Ali from whom it passed from imam to imam until it came into Jafar's possession.

According to Jafar, the Prophet entrusted Ali with the greatest name of God and the traditions pertaining to the knowledge of prophethood. Ali was said to have been versed in the Qur'an. The Prophet is reported to have said of him: "I am the city of knowledge and Ali is its gate". With Ali's knowledge in religious matters, inheritance of this knowledge became a source of claim of special rights for the legitimate imams of the house of the Prophet or the *Ahl al-Bayt*.

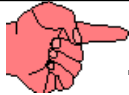
Note



The imamate therefore rotates around the principles of *nass* and *'ilm* which are fused into an unitary vision of religious leadership that it is impossible to separate one from the other

According to the doctrine of imamate as propounded by Jafar, it was not necessary at all for a divinely appointed imam to stage a rebellion in order to become a ruler. As a spiritual leader of the community, Jafar argued that his place was above that of a ruler who should only carry out what an imam decides as a supreme authority of religion.

Note



The imamate, according to Jafar is bequeathed from father to son, but not necessarily to the eldest son.

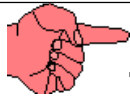
In accordance with the above, the imam designates his successor the son that he actually considers most worthy of the office. Accordingly, Jafar disinherited his eldest son Ismail as his successor, ignored Abdullah, his second son and nominated the third Musa al-Kazim. Jafar also proclaimed that the imamate is a covenant between God and humankind and the recognition of the imam is an absolute duty of every believer. He argued that: "whoever dies without having known and acknowledged the imam of his time dies as an infidel".

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The imams are proofs (*hujja*) of God on earth; their words are the words of God. Obedience to them is obedience to God, and disobedience to them is disobedience to God. God inspires the imams in all their decisions. They have absolute authority from God. In them God has ordained obedience (4:59). The imam of a given time is the people's witness. He is the gate of God, road to God, a Guide, Repository of God's knowledge and Interpreter of God's revelations. The imam is a pillar of God's unity. He is immune from sin and error (*masum*). From the imams, God has removed all impurity and made them absolutely pure (33:33). They possess the power of performing miracles and of irrefutable arguments. They protect the people on earth, hence though absent, they are present in spirit at the devotions of his fold. The expounders of the law and the ministers of religion are the imams' representatives on earth. God delegates to the imams spiritual leadership over the whole world. They should always have an imam as a leader and a guide.

There are also two imams according to Jafar: the actual or "speaking imam" (*natiq*) and his son - successor who during the lifetime of the father is "silent" (*samit*). The silent imam does not know of his position until his father's death. At that juncture, he is entrusted with the scriptures and secrets of religion. After the death of an imam (the father), the son takes over and become proof (*al-Hujja*) for humankind.

Note



The concept of *nass* and '*ilm*' made Jafar to limit the scope of the *Ahl al-Bayt* since all the descendants of Ali whether through Fatima or not claimed membership to the *Ahl al-Bayt*.

The Abbasids also claimed this same right to the household of the Prophet. Jafar limited the applicability of the term *Ahl al-Bayt* was therefore by to Ali, Fatima and their descendants, from whom all kinds of uncleanliness were removed. With time Jafar established the sanctity of the *Ahl al-Bayt* through the help of traditions, as an inherited quality confined only to those of the children of Fatima who were ordained to be imams. In this way he rejected the claims of all other Hashimites, Alids and the Abbasids.

The hereditary claim to the imamate based on the principles of *nass* and '*ilm*' greatly exposed the claimants to the danger of persecution by the Abbasids, who also claimed spiritual leadership of the community.



What were the consequences of that?

Consequently the doctrine of *taqiyya* (dissimulation) was developed as a corollary or natural outcome of the prevalent circumstances of the time and an inevitable necessity imposed by the danger of following certain religious or political views. *Taqiyya* was propounded and formalised by Jafar as a doctrine of Shia faith. *Taqiyya* is not telling a lie or falsehood but the protection of true religion and its followers from the enemies through concealment in circumstances where there is fear of being killed, captured or insulted.

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6.4.4 Summary



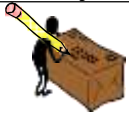
In this lesson we have discussed the Shi'a doctrine of the imamate. The doctrine was founded by the fourth and fifth imams of the Shi'a but elaborated by the 6th imam, Jafar as-Sadiq. The doctrine is founded on two fundamental principles. That is the principles of nass and 'ilm. The two principles are hereditary and limited the imamate to the *Ahl al-Bayt*. Limiting the scope of the *Ahl al-Bayt* exposed its members to danger of persecution from other members especially the Abbasids who also claimed leadership of the *Ahl al-Bayt*. Consequently, to guard its members against the danger of persecution, the doctrine of *taqiyya* was put in place.

6.4.5 Key Words



'ilm: knowledge; among the Shi'a this is the esoteric knowledge possessed by those who are the descendants of the Prophet through Ali and Fatima
imam: spiritual leader/leader of prayers in a mosque/ appointed leader of Friday prayers or the holder of supreme religious and political authority
nass: explicit designation based on the Shi'a belief that leadership is passed on from father to son among the descendants of the Prophet through Ali and Fatima
taqiyya: dissimulation/prudent fear, a doctrine of the Shi'a.

6.4.6 Activity



Comment on the Shi'a doctrine of the imamate.

6.4.7 Further Reading



Al-Kashifu'l-ghita, A.S.M.H. 1993. **The Origin of Shi'ite Islam and its Principles**, pp.112-115
Ali, A. 1974. **The Spirit of Islam**. p. 314
Jafri, S.H.M. 1979. **Origins and Early development of Shi'a Islam**, pp.293-297
Tabatabai, A.S.M.H. 1981. **Shi'a**, pp.173-217

LECTURE 7: THE SUNNI SCHOOLS OF LAW (MADHAHAB)

7.1 The Sunni Schools of Law 1: Hanafi and Maliki Schools of Jurisprudence

7.1.1 Introduction

In lessons 6.1 and 6.2, we looked at the development of sectarianism in Islam, specifically the division between the Sunni and the Shi'a. In those lessons, it is also shown that the Sunni form the majority of the Muslims. In this lesson we are going to identify the four schools of Sunni law, and examine the lives of the founders of Hanafi and Maliki schools and discuss their teachings.

7.1.2 Objectives



- To identify the four schools of Sunni law.
- To examine the life of the founders of the Hanafi and Maliki schools and discuss their teachings.

7.1.3 Content

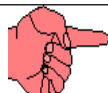
The Sunni base their doctrines on the entirety of the Qur'an and the traditions of the Prophet. They regard the concordant decisions of the successive orthodox caliphs i.e. Abu Bakr, Umar, Uthman, and Ali, and of the general consensus of assemblies of the community as supplementing the Qur'anic rules and regulations, and the traditions of the Prophet. The Sunni has four schools of law.



Which are the four Sunni schools of law (*fiqh*: jurisprudence)?

These schools are Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i and Hanbali. These schools are variously known as schools of law (*madhahab*), schools of jurisprudence (*fiqh*) or schools of thought.

Note



These schools differ from each other on minor points of dogma and doctrines, but they agree on the fundamental bases or principles of their doctrines of the laws deriving them from the Qur'an, Traditions (*Hadith* or *Sunna*), *ijma*-consensus of the jurists - and *Qiyas* - analogical deductions.

The four imams and founders of the schools were teachers and pupils of each other, all working for a common goal of serving the Muslim community.

Hanafi School of Jurisprudence

It is the first school of Sunni law, founded by Imam Abu Hanifa, a non-Arab Muslim who was born in around 80 AH and died in Kufa in 150 A.H. (750 CE) during the reign of the Abbasid caliph Al-Mansur. Hanifa belonged to the period of the successors (*tabiun*) of the *shahaba* of the Prophet. He was brought up as a trader but soon started taking deep interest in education at a time when Islamic learning was being spread by the great *tabii* scholars and imams. He attended lectures of Hammad in Kufa [Sheikh Hammad was a famous educationist who founded this famous school in Kufa] in *Fiqh* and then began his study on

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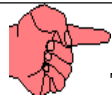
Hadith. After completing his education in Kufah and Basrah, Abu Hanifa went to Mecca and Medina and enrolled as a student of the famous scholar Ata bin Abi Umar, the son of Caliph Umar who recognized his merits.

His fame as a great scholar and his intellectual gifts and originality spread far and wide and also increased the adverse remarks of his being a *Qayyas* – one who makes analogical deductions. He also learnt from Imam Malik who was 13 years his junior. He attended his lectures and learned *ahadith* (singular: *hadith*), from Malik who used to receive him with great respect and used to make him sit besides him. Hanifa learnt *ahadith* from at least 4000 scholars and attended so many schools to acquaint himself with special and different principles and methods present at the time so that by a comparative study of them, he could arrive at some system of his own.

His merit was recognized by his teacher Hammad and had become a real *mujtahid* but due to his sincere regard, he refrained from establishing a school of his own even though he was 40 years of age.

After the death of his teacher, he founded his own school. He settled down to teach and became so famous that everywhere he travelled, people gathered round him for interviews, discussions and debates with him. His students came from all over the world. He lectured on Hadith and Islamic law and had a group of teachers who were specialised in different aspects of Islam. With his disciples, he thoroughly investigated and discussed each and every legal problem that was presented to him, and recorded all the answers. Equally, in case of different opinions, he collected all the opinions. In this way, he was able to amass a lot of decisions for many legal points. This enabled him to have a systematic collection of the laws that established the principles of *fiqh* that led to the founding of the Hanafi School of Jurisprudence that was the first school of law in the Muslim world.

Note



The Hanafi School of Law is predominant in the Middle East – Iraq, Iran - and Central Asia – India and Pakistan.

He objected accepting the post of a *qadhi* during the reign of the Abbasid caliph Al-Mansur. He died of food poisoning. He was imprisoned for his recalcitrance but his popularity enabled him to continue teaching even in prison, a situation the caliph misconstrued as a danger to his authority, so he instigated his poisoning. Let us now turn to the second school of law.

Maliki School of Jurisprudence

It is the second school of law. It was founded by Imam Malik bin Anas, born in Medina in 93 A.H. during the Umayyad caliphate specifically during the reign of al-Walid I. He was a keen scholar who learnt the *ahadith* at an early age. He learnt the Qur'an by heart and also studied Hadith and *Fiqh*. His appeal in the fields of *hadith* and *Fiqh* came from people such as Umar, the second caliph; his son Abdallah bin Umar; Zayyid bin Thabit; Al-Abbas, the uncle of the Prophet; and Ayesha, the Prophet's wife.

He was the first scholar to formulate the principles on the traditions and customs of the people of Medina. He wrote the **Muwatta** (literally means: the trodden path) in which he collected all his thoughts on the religious issues in the forefront. He also wrote chapters on *Hadith*, *Fiqh*, Theology and other related topics.

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Note

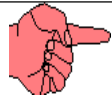


In his interpretation, Imam Malik relied on the Holy Qur'an, the Sunnah and resorted to al-Qiyas wherever necessary.

He used legal reasoning and equity in much the same way as Hanafi School. Thus he sought guidance from the works of Imam Abu Hanifa. He selected basic texts from the Holy Qur'an and matched them with corresponding *ahadith*; searching for arguments for and against them before arriving at a decision.

Imam Malik was a keen educationist. He also wrote books on other topics and delivered lectures to students, young and old, common or royal on matters of *Fiqh* and *Hadith*. He died at the age of 86 years in 795 CE (179 AH). The **Muwatta** which are the dictations of Imam Malik and compilations of his disciples, led to the formation of the Maliki School of Jurisprudence. His disciples carried on his ideas and developed them.

Note



His teachings gained wide acceptance in the Muslim world particularly Western Arabia, Egypt, North Africa, West Africa and Spain.

As a great *muhadithin* (scholar and authority on the science of Hadith), he scrutinized all kinds of narrations, sermons of the Prophet, expansion on Qur'an and other stories, sayings about excellences and biographical narrations by the Companions of the Prophet, and the explanations of the Qur'an and Hadith by the Companions and their way of life. He then compiled about a thousand *ahadith* after careful consideration in his famous Muwatta. All his legal theories and its codification are based on the Hadith and *Sunna* of the Prophet. His legal theories and decisions required the use of *ijtihad*. As a jurist, he fearlessly gave his *fatawa* (religious decrees or juristic decisions) even if the ruling caliph disliked.

7.1.4 Summary

In this lesson, we have identified the four schools of Sunni law. We have also examined the lives of the founder of the Hanafi and Maliki schools and discussed their teachers. Notably, the two schools do not differ radically on the main principles of the sources of Islamic law. The lesson also highlights the various areas of the Muslim world where these schools are predominant.

7.1.5 Key Words



ijtihad:	the use of independent judgement or original thinking in interpreting the Qur'an and the Sunna; a process whereby decisions could be arrived at from the evidence contained in all the four sources of the law.
madhahab:	one of the four schools of Sunni law.
mujtahid:	one who uses ijtihad.
muhadithin:	scholar and authority on the science of Hadith.
Muwatta:	literally means: the trodden path; the Hadith collections of Imam Malik.

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7.1.6 Activities



- Examine the lives of Imams Abu Hanifa and Muhammad al-Shafi'i.
- Discuss the teachings of the Hanafi and Shafi'i schools of jurisprudence.

7.1.7 Further Reading



Quraishy, M.A. 1987. **Textbook of Islam**, Book 2. Nairobi: Islamic Foundation, pp.173-178

Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, pp. 98-105; 164-167

Schacht, J. 1969. **An Introduction to Islamic Law**. Oxford at the Clarendon Press, pp. 23-57

Lesson 7.2 The Sunni Schools of Law 2: Shafi'i and Hanbali Schools of Jurisprudence

7.2.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson, we identified the four Sunni schools of law. We also examined the lives of the founders of the Hanafi and Maliki schools and their teachings. In this lesson, we will examine the lives of the founders of Shafi'i and Hanbali schools and discuss their teachings.

7.2.2 Objectives



To examine the life of the founders of Shafi'i and Hanbali schools and discuss their teachings.

7.2.3 Content



Which is the third school law?

The Shafi'i School

It is the third school of Sunni law, founded by Imam Muhammad Idris al-Shafi'i who was born in 767 A.D (150 AH). He belonged to the tribe of the Prophet Muhammad. After the death of his father, his mother took him to Mecca where he devoted himself to learning. At the age of 10, he had learnt the **Muwatta** of Imam Malik. He studied *Fiqh* and *Hadith* under eminent scholars and then went to Medina to learn more from Imam Malik himself. Thus, he was a student of Imam Malik and a follower of the Maliki School of law. He studied in depth under Imam Malik and became an expert in Maliki school of thought.

He left Baghdad in 188 AH (804 AD) and then travelled to Mecca where he lectured at the Grand Mosque and met Imam Ibn Hanbal, a young disciple of Imam Malik. Later he went to Egypt, which was then a Maliki country, where he hoped to pursue studies.

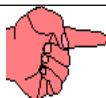
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He always looked on religious matters with an independent legal reasoning. He was a keen teacher and skilful debater, but at times he differed with his Maliki colleagues. Though an expert in Maliki law, in Baghdad, he had a new opportunity to go deep into the Hanafi School of jurisprudence. He lived with Hanafi jurists and discussed with them on legal issues defending the position of his master Imam Malik. Thus Imam Shafi'i studied in depth both the Maliki and Hanafi schools. He died in 860 A.D. (204 AH) in Cairo where he was buried and a mausoleum was later erected.

Most of the logical conclusions of Imam Shafi'i are preserved in two books: **Kitab al-Risalah fi usul al-Fiqh (Kitab al-Risalah)** and **Kitab al-Umm**. *Risalah* means communication made in writing to an absent person. It is in actual fact a record of a debate between him and another scholar on points of religion and law. In this book, he explained in a systematic way the legal significance of both the Holy Qur'an and the *Sunna*. He accepted the principle of *al-ijma* on the grounds that it involved the whole community. He also agreed to the admission of *al-Qiyas* with some modifications in points of law. In **Kitab al-Umm**, he dealt mainly with discussions with other jurists e.g. Abu Yusuf and Imam Muhammad. He paid high tribute to the imams Abu Hanifa and Malik for their service to the development of the *shariah*.

He also wrote on the Hadith and other topics. He made a deep study of the Holy Qur'an, the *Sunna* and the legal opinions of the learned scholars of his era.

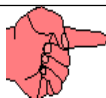
Note



Ahmad bin Hanbal placed the Holy Quran and the *Sunna* in the same class as a source of the *shariah* in that both were derived from God but manifested in different ways for the benefit of humankind.

Some of his disciples were Ahmad bin Hanbal the founder of the Hanbali School and Daud Zahiri the founder of the Zahiri School and Abu Thaur al-Baghdadi the founder of the Thauri School.

Note



This school is predominant in Egypt, Syria, Iraq, Southern and Western Arabia, Hijaz, India, Persia, East Indies, North Africa, Spain, Sri Lanka and East Africa.

Hanbali School of Jurisprudence

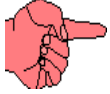
The fourth and last school of Sunni law is the Hanbali, founded by Imam Ahmad ibn Hanbal. He was born in Baghdad in 780 A.D (164 AH). He lost his father at an early age. He memorized the Holy Qur'an by heart and studied other branches of knowledge like Hadith and *Fiqh* for which he was a keen student. He became a pupil of Imam Abu Yusuf and other Iraqi jurists.

From 179 AH (795 AD), he travelled widely in Persia, Iraq, Syria, Arabia and Yemen and developed a keen interest in collecting and learning *Sunnah*. He studied finer points of law under Imam Shafi'i. He led a life of piety and poverty; refused to accept gifts that he thought were a prelude to one becoming corrupt. His strong will, high character and patience earned him the respect of the people.

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He opposed strongly the Mutazilite beliefs. The Mutazilites were philosophers who used reason to defend religion and believed that any religious tenet had to be subjected to the test of reason. Among other beliefs, they held that the Holy Qur'an was created and not divine and denied predestination. The Mutazilite teachings were predominant during the reign of the Abbasid caliph Al-Mamun. As a result of Ahmad bin Hanbal's opposition to the Mutazilites, he was imprisoned by Caliph al-Mamun and Caliph Mu'tasim had him flogged (see Lesson 5.3). After his release from prison, he lived in retirement. Though he was allowed to preach by Caliph Mutawwakkil, due to ill health and advanced age he died in 855 A.D (241 AH) and was buried in the martyrs' graveyard in Baghdad.

Note



In Fiqh methodology, Ahmad bin Hanbal is placed among the *muhadithin* than a *faqih* (jurist). This is because of his masterly collection of the traditions of the Prophet called al-**Musnad**.

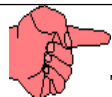
His disciples collected and systematized his methods and principles on law. These were mainly in form of replies to be put in writings so that stress be given to his methods and legal factors of his time. All these works gave rise to the founding of the Hanbali School of Jurisprudence.

His approach was that of following the text of the Holy Qur'an very closely and considered the *Sunnah* to be its explanation. He preferred the decisions of the rightly guided caliphs, accepted the *ijma* of the Companions but took a middle view on al-Qiyas that he resorted to only if it was agreeable to the sacred sources of the law, i.e. Holy Qur'an and Sunna.

His ideas on the principles and methods of administration of law gained acceptance through the writings of his disciples and followers. They also made use of the principle of *ijtihad* a process whereby decisions could be arrived at from the evidence contained in all the four sources of the law. They used to solve problems through this principle with some variations from the techniques used by other schools of law.

In the later centuries, there was opposition to the Hanbali principles mainly due to the competition with other schools. It remained relatively dormant until its revival in the 7th century of the Hijra when Imam Taqi ad-Din Ahmmed ibn Taimiyya wrote several treatises on the Hanbali approach. He became its greatest pupil and in his writings denounced the practices that had corrupted Islam. Sheikh Abdul Wahhab who founded the Wahhabi movement in Arabia further improved the efforts of Ibn Taimiyya. Wahhab popularised the Hanbali School of Law and it was adopted by the Saud dynasty that overthrew the Ottoman rule in Arabia. Presently, this school is predominant in Arabia, Syria, Palestine and parts of Asia.

Note



The followers of the Hanbali School are regarded as People of the traditions (*Ahl al-Hadith*) because of their insistence on following the Qur'an and the Hadith to the letter.

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7.2.4 Summary



This lesson has examined the lives of Imams Shafi'i and Ahmad bin Hanbal and discussed the teachings of the Shafi'i and Hanbali schools of law. We have also mentioned the various parts of the Muslim world that these schools are predominant. The role of Imam Ahmad bin Hanbal in opposing the Mutazilite doctrines is highlighted. It is notable that the Hanbali School is the most conservative of all the four schools of Sunni law.

7.2.5 Activities



- Examine the lives of Imams Muahammad al-Shafi'i and Ahmad bin Hanbal.
- Discuss the teachings of Maliki and Hanbali schools and assess their contributions in the development of Islamic law.

7.2.6 Further Reading



Quraishy, M.A. 1987. **Textbook of Islam**, Book 2, pp.178-183
Lapidus, I.M. 1994. **A History of Islamic Societies**, pp. 98-105; 164-167
Schacht, J. 1969. **An Introduction to Islamic Law**, pp.57-68

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Lecture 8: ISLAMIC EDUCATION

Lesson 8.1 Origin and Sources of Islamic Education

8.1.1 Introduction

The development and growth of education has been discussed briefly in the previous lectures, specifically under the achievements of the four orthodox caliphs, the Umayyads and the Abbasid dynasties. This lesson examines in details the origin of Islamic education and its basis in the Qur'an and *hadith*.

8.1.2 Objectives



- To define the terms education and knowledge in Islam
- To discuss the origin of education in Islam and its basis in the Qur'an and Hadith

8.1.3 Content

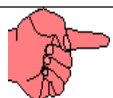
The term “education” in Islam is derived from the Arabic word *ta'lim*. Similarly, the term “knowledge” is derived from the Arabic word *'ilm*, a generic term that is also applied to the term “science”. Another term that connotes “education” is *tarbiyya* that means “learning”. Other terms that are used in close relation to the word “education” are contemplation (*tadabbur*), comprehension (*taffaqquh*), thinking (*tafakkur*) and wisdom (*ta'aqqul*) among many others.

The foundation of education and knowledge in Islam is the first chapter of the revelation of the Qur'an. This chapter attests to the need to acquire knowledge and education in the following words:

Proclaim (or read)! In the name of thy Lord and Cherisher, who created man out of a (mere) clot of congealed blood. Read! And thy Lord is the most bountiful. He who taught (the use of) the pen. Taught man that which he knew not (96:1-5).

The words of the revelation gave Prophet Muhammad the authority to convey the divine message to humankind through “reading” and “writing”. Through the spoken and the written word, the Prophet became a teacher. His task was to convey the divine word. Therefore, the first revelation was a challenge to Muslims to take to literacy.

Note



Besides the first revelation, that is the cornerstone of education in Islam, the Holy Qur'an has many verses and expressions that stress on the importance of knowledge and education.

Some of these expressions have been mentioned at the beginning of this section. Others are *albab* (minds), *aql* (reason). The word *'ilm* (knowledge) with its derivatives occurs 805 times in the Qur'an; *albab* occurs 16 times while *aql*, occurs 49 times.



Which are some of the Qur'anic verses that talk about knowledge and education?

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Chapter 68:1-2 highlights the value and dignity of knowledge by swearing by the pen. God is presented as the source of knowledge (wisdom) in chapter 2:269. The value of knowledge is highlighted, by identifying it with those who fear Allah (35:28). Lack of true knowledge leads people to revile the true God (6:108). Those who do not possess knowledge are considered as a class lower to those who possess it (39:9). The only safety lies in following the revelation that is replete with the knowledge of God (11:14).

The cultivation of learning and reasoning can also be deduced from the constant Qur'anic injunctions that call for Muslims "to know", "to see", "to ponder", "to think", and to "deduce" (2:219; 2:114). Muslims are supposed to contemplate about the wonders of creation (3:119). Similarly, one should "reflect" on the wonderful signs that God has bestowed on humankind (30:21). And that all who "know" should be able to tell the signs of God in the creation (30:22). The people who do not "understand" are depicted as the ones destined for hell (7:179; 8:22).

The possession of knowledge coupled with faith and practice are seen as the prerequisites for the religion of Islam. For the person who possesses those qualities there are promises of good rewards and high ranks (58:11). The possession of knowledge by human beings is the factor that has made them to be superior to the other creatures created by God. The supremacy of human beings surpasses that of angels (2:31-34).

It is obligatory for the believers to acquire the knowledge of religion, to have wisdom and possess deep intellectual knowledge. For this reason, God sent the Prophet to humankind (2:151). Having looked at the Qur'an and the importance it attaches to education, let us now turn our attention to the Hadith and see how it reaffirms the Qur'an's on the same issue.



How does the Hadith re-affirms the teachings of the Qur'an on the importance of learning?

The Prophet had to propagate the message of Islam through educating the people. By so doing imbuing them with the spirit and ideals of Islam and preparing them for a fully-grown life. In this task, the Prophet was fulfilling the prophetic function as was required of him (62:2; 2:51).

The Prophet used various methods to teach his companions the divine message, the practices of Islamic faith and his *sunna* (way of life; conduct and practices). These methods were: verbal, dictation and practical demonstrations. He entrusted the Companions of the Prophet and other believers who learnt in the circle of the Prophet, with the responsibility of teaching others who embraced Islam. He would tell them: "convey my message to the people even if it is only one verse" and "those in attendance should convey the message to those absent".

The *Hadith* of the Prophet is replete with messages that extol knowledge in one way or another. The Prophet for example recognized the importance of knowledge in the following words: "the men of knowledge are the inheritors of the prophets" and "he dies not who seeks knowledge". The Prophet did not lay any limit in the pursuit of knowledge. He urged Muslims to: "seek knowledge even though in China" and "seek knowledge from the cradle to the grave".

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The Prophet expressed the virtues of knowledge by saying: “wisdom is the lost property of the believer; wherever he finds it, he has a right to it”. He also expressed the acquisition of knowledge as being part and parcel of one’s faith, since it enhances one’s devotion to God. He said:

Acquire knowledge; he who acquires knowledge in the way of Allah performs an act of piety; he who speaks of it praises the Lord; he who seeks it adores God; he who dispenses instruction in it bestows alms; he who imparts it to the deserving persons performs an act of devotion.

Education is an aspect of life that Muslim parents are enjoined to avail their children. To that effect a *hadith* of the Prophet says:

A father can confer on his children nothing more valuable than the gift of education. It is better that a man should secure a good education for his children than he should leave a treasure of gold and silver to them.

The Prophet considered the pursuit of knowledge far superior to religious devotion. He said:

To listen to the instructions of science and learning for one hour is more meritorious than attending the funerals of a thousand martyrs, more meritorious than standing up in prayer for a thousand nights.

The rewards of scholarship and for those who seek knowledge are highlighted by the traditions of the Prophet. He said:

To the student who go forth in quest for knowledge, God will allot a high place in the mansions of bliss; every step he takes is blessed and every lesson he receives has its reward”.

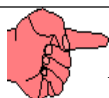
Similarly:

The seeker of knowledge will be greeted in heaven with a welcome from the angel: to listen to the words of the learned and to instil into the heart the lessons of science is better than religious exercises ... better than emancipating a hundred slaves.

The Prophet also took cognisance of the role of the learned (*ulema*) in society by saying: “he who honours the learned, honours me”. He also gave a special recognition to the *ulema* and said: “he who favours learning and the learned God will favour in the next world”. And: “on the day of judgement the ink which the learned men use in writing their works will be equal in value to the blood of martyrs”.

All the above sayings and others clearly depict the Prophet’s high regard for education and learning in general. It is on that regard that he made education obligatory to all Muslims as expressed by one of his oft quoted sayings: “acquisition of knowledge is incumbent upon all Muslims, male and female”.

Note

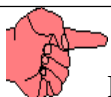


With the death of the Prophet in 632 CE, the torch of learning was carried by his companions

Caliph Umar bin Khattab (632-644) ascribed Muslims to: “teach your boys swimming, archery, horse-riding and poetry”. Caliph Ali (656-661) lectured on various branches of learning that were suited to the needs of the growing community. He is quoted to have said that: “eminence in science is the highest of honours” and “the greatest ornament of man is erudition”. Ibn Abbas the uncle of the Prophet lectured on poetry, grammar, history and mathematics. Others among the first generation of teachers were Aisha (wife of the Prophet); Zayyid ibn Thabit, personal scribe of the Prophet; and Abdallah ibn Umar, among others.

From the very beginning of Islamic education, the Qur'an and *Hadith* were the main subjects. In time other subjects were studied such as Grammar, Rhetoric (art of public speaking) and *Fiqh* (Islamic jurisprudence). The development of the science of *Hadith* also took place. This incorporated the science of judging the reliability of the transmission, writing and studying the life of transmitters. With the study of *Fiqh* grew the different schools of Law such as Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi and Hanbali of Sunni Islam and Jafari of Shi'a Islam.

Note



From its inception the curriculum of Islamic education was largely religious, i.e. religious subjects predominated

8.1.4 Summary



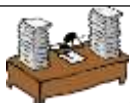
This lesson has examined the various terms that relate to education and knowledge in Islam and their basis in the Qur'an and Hadith. It is shown that the Qur'an and *Hadith* legitimise education and knowledge in Islam. Various Qur'anic verses and sayings of the Prophet have been used to demonstrate the importance that Islam accords to education and seeking knowledge. It is demonstrated that Prophet Muhammad laid the foundation of education for Muslims. the genesis of this education was the first revelation that the Prophet experienced.

8.1.5 Activities



- Define the Islamic concept of education.
- Assess how the Qur'an and Hadith provide a basis for Islamic education.

8.1.6 Further Reading



- Ali, A. 1974. **The Spirit of Islam**, p.362
- Maina, N.K. 1993. "Muslim Education in Kenya with Special Reference to *Madrasa* System in Nairobi" M.A thesis, Kenyatta University, pp.
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Lesson 8.2 The Features of Traditional Islamic Education

8.2.1 Introduction

Having looked at the origin of Islamic education and its derivatives from the Qur'an and Hadith, let us now look at the features of traditional Islamic education. These features distinguish traditional Islamic education from modern formal education.

8.2.2 Objective



To discuss the main features of traditional Islamic education that distinguish it from formal modern education

8.2.3 Content

There are several features of traditional Islamic education that uniquely distinguish it from formal modern education.

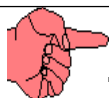


Which were the features of traditional Islamic education?

The following were the features of traditional Islamic education:

(a) Traditional Islamic education was not examination oriented. There were no diplomas or certificates. A student grew into a level of education that he/she aspired without any form of coercion whatsoever. After the completion of a particular course with a given teacher, a student was issued with an *ijaza* (pl. *ijazat*). This was a kind of licence that authorized the holder to teach the subject of his specialization.

Note



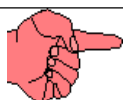
The value of an *ijaza* was determined by name and the prestige of the teacher who issued it.

(b) Islamic education was not confined to place and time. Muslim scholars were itinerant in nature. They combed the entire length and breadth of the Islamic world in search of their own choice of teachers. These seekers after knowledge joined the circles of the learned men in distant lands. In so doing these scholars were obeying the words of the Prophet Muhammad who enjoined Muslims: "to seek knowledge even though in China".

(c) Traditional Islamic education was entirely free. The teacher was not expected to charge fees for rendering his/her services. However, direct payment of a student to a teacher was restricted to the early stages of education (in the *maktab*). It was expected that teachers of the elementary levels be subsisted for their work. That also applied to teachers who taught literary subjects. All those who taught religious subjects did not receive any reward.

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Note



Teaching was considered a religious duty. Teachers were therefore expected to teach gratuitously (without pay).



How then were the material needs of the teachers met?

The material needs of the teachers and to a larger extent the students of higher institutions were met by local contributions and rich generous religious endowments (*wakf*: [pl. *awkaḥ*]). The *wakf wakf* was derived from charity, endowments of land and other immovable properties by a deed of restraint (*wakf*). The property so restrained was withdrawn from all further transfer of ownership and its usufruct devoted to a specific object designated by the donor. The *awkaḥ* were created by rulers and individuals and the objects for which it was founded were religious institutions like mosques; educational institutions; public works such as roads, bridges, water conduits and light houses; charitable organizations and institutions such as hospitals, hostels, houses for widows, and so on.

The status of a teacher depended to a larger extent on the level he/she taught. The teacher of an elementary school was called *mu'allim* and occupied a rather low status due to his/her theological training. But the teacher of the higher grade (institution) was highly respected.

(d) Teaching was not just a profession to be sold but was a role to be performed fully and completely. The relationship between the teacher and his/her student(s) was governed by a deep affection for one another. He/she was the source of spiritual and moral guidance to better knowledge and a model to be emulated. In such a situation, the student(s) looked upon the teacher as father figure who was to be obeyed in even personal matters. Regardless of the status of the teacher, the relationship governed by his close contact with the pupils made him an important person in the community with a noble role to perform.

(e) Traditional Islamic education used various methods to impart the values of society.



Which were these methods?

These methods were: dictation, oral recitation, oral exposition and rote learning. Rote learning was stressed at all levels. A teacher could teach from a given text by commentary or dictation. He always concluded his lesson with the words (formula) “and God knows best”). It was an acceptable custom for the students of all ages to show courtesy to their teacher by kissing his right hand after the lesson. Later a “repeater” would repeat the master’s lesson for the benefit of those who did not follow. The repeater was usually one of the bright students chosen by the teacher. It was a recognized practice for students to raise questions and argue with the teacher in the course of the lesson. This method made the up-coming scholars to make names for them and they were earmarked for the future leadership roles for the circles.

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The final feature that distinguished Traditional Islamic education from modern education was its less dependence for its operation on specific administrative, institutional and organizational patterns. Education was a life long process in which an individual could remain a student till old age or death. In the same class sat pupils of different ages, young and old alike, with different abilities and participating in various learning activities. In this way the dull benefited from the brilliant and the able. The able and studious were allowed to progress at their own speed. In such a learning situation, therefore, there was no rigid curriculum to be followed.

Traditional Islamic education got its inspiration from the Qur'an and Hadith. The two sources helped Muslims to define and evolve Islamic education thought. With expansion of Islam, contacts were made with Greek, Chinese, Indian, Jewish, Christian and Persian civilizations. Islam adopted and assimilated some of the intellectual ideas and values of these civilizations that were blended with Islamic principles. The product was a new corpus of knowledge based on Arabic translations.

Traditional Islamic education managed to produce various scholars and alumnae that included: physicians, writers, poets, astronomers, philosophers, historians and mathematicians among others. These scholars made remarkable and lasting contributions to the development of Islamic civilization and modern science. After the decline of ancient sciences, – Greek, Roman, Persian and Chinese – Muslim scholars kept alight the flame of knowledge through the various Arabic translations (see Lessons 9.4, 9.5 and 9.6). The western world later borrowed these Islamic works and translated them. The result was the Renaissance that heralded the age of discovery and modern education. Muslim educational institutions equally played a great role in re-awakening modern Europe to modern learning. An example of such institutions is Al-Azhar University in Cairo, Egypt. Reputed to be one of the oldest universities in the world, Al-Azhar celebrated its thousandth anniversary in 1969.

8.2.4 Summary



This lesson has examined the features of traditional Islamic education that makes it distinct from modern education. It is shown that traditional Islamic education was not examination oriented. It was free because teaching was considered a religious duty and employed various methods such as dictation, oral recitation and exposition and rote learning. In addition, traditional Islamic education did not rely on specific administrative, institutional and organizational patterns. Finally the lesson shows that traditional Islamic education, which got its inspiration from the Qur'an and hadith, produced remarkable scholars who made enormous contributions to Islamic civilization and modern science.

8.2.5 Key Words



ijaza (pl. *ijazat*): licence that authorized the holder to teach the subject of his specialization.

Maktab: elementary institution of Islamic education

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8.2.6 Activities



- Assess the main features of traditional Islamic education.
- Thus the contention that “the traditional system of Islamic education is not only obsolete, but also ineffective”. Discuss

8.2.6 Further Reading



- Badawi, M.A.Z. 1979. "Traditional Islamic Education, its Aims and Purpose", in World Conference on Muslim Education, 1st Mecca, 1977. **Aims and Objectives of Islamic Education**. Al-Attas, S.M.A (ed). Hodder & Stoughton, pp.126-133
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Lesson 8.3: Institutions of Islamic Education

8.3.1 Introduction

In the last two lessons we looked at the Islamic education, its origin and the features of traditional Islamic education. Let us now turn our attention to the institutions that were used to impart that education.

8.3.2 Objectives



To identify and discuss some of the institutions early Islamic education.

8.3.3 Content



Which were some of these educational institutions?

With the establishment and outward growth of Islamic society, educational institutions came into being. Early Muslim educational institutions were: the mosque, the *maktab* (pl. *makatib*), the *halqah* (circle or gathering) of the learned and the madrasa. Let us look at each of these institutions separately.

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The Mosque

This was the first place where teaching was done. The mosque was the hub of all Muslim communal activities: political, religious, judicial and educational. Religious edification and state policy were proclaimed in the mosque. Justice was also dispensed within the confines of a mosque. The preacher sat there and also teachers who were surrounded by adults and children who sought instruction.

The use of mosque for educational purposes began during the time of the Prophet and continued during the reign of the Orthodox caliphs. To date the mosque has not dispensed with these noble roles of serving the community. In this respect the centrality of the mosque to the entire life of the Muslims carries with it the educational role. The mosque brings together Muslims from all walks of life. This becomes an opportunity for exchanging of ideas and enhances solidarity, unity of purpose and action. The *Jumu'ah* (Friday) congregational prayers are an occasion when Muslims come together. The Friday Sermon is a very important educational resource for Muslims, as the khutba delves into a wide range of issues affecting the welfare of the Muslims.

The Maktab and the Halqah

Instruction in Arabic language and Islamic religion in the formative years of Islamic history brought about a class of private teachers. The teachers demanded and charged fees for the services they rendered. The demand for teachers led to the formation of a teaching service. As a result special rooms were set aside for teaching. Such rooms assigned for the instruction came to be regarded as *makatib*, *kuttab* or *khelwa*.

The *maktab* was an elementary school that could be held in a private house shop or could be an adjunct of a mosque. It was presided over by a mu'allim (teacher). The maktab acquainted the learner with the knowledge of reading and writing and the basic principles of Islam. Its curriculum was centred on the Qur'an as the main subject. Other subjects were Arabic grammar, Hadith, Arabic philology, simple arithmetic notions, etc.

Besides the maktab, there was the halqah or *majlis* (pl. *majalis*) that means "circle" or "gathering" of the learned. This was presided over by a *Sheikh* or *Hakim* (learned person or wise man). The halqah (majlis) was a place where various religious and philosophical sciences were discussed. Aspiring scholars and whoever could benefit regardless of age or academic standards attended. The *halqah* could be held within the confines of a mosque.

Madrassa

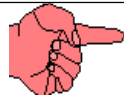
The halqah and the makatib acted as educational institutions until the fourth century A.H (10th century CE) when a need was felt to expand the existing educational institutions. In the 11th century (CE), institutions of higher learning or universities reached the climax of their development. This was marked by the establishment of a chain of colleges called *madrassa* (pl. *madaris*). These were built in Baghdad, Nishapur and other cities by the Seljuq sultan, Nizam al-Mulk. The *madrassa* was from then extended with some modifications to other parts of the Muslim world, for example, in Jerusalem in 1189 CE, in North Africa the *madrassa* was put up by the Almoravids and in Granada was built in 1349 CE and also the al-Attarin Mosque in Fez, Morocco. *Madaris* were also put up in Central Asia and the Shia Saavid dynasty founded theirs in Isfahan, Meshed and Shiraz. Some of these higher institutions of learning still flourish like the Qairawiyin in Fez, Morocco that is 11 centuries old and reputed to be one of the oldest universities in the world. They also include al-Azhar that was originally founded as a Shiite institution, but later became a

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centre of Sunni learning; Najaf founded in the 11th century (CE) is a Shiite centre of learning and one of the largest religious universities in the Muslim world.

The Sunni *madrasa* was essentially established to train students in sacred law and other religious sciences. Its program consisted of the study of the Qur'an, Hadith, *Tafsir* - exegesis, Arabic, and literature, law, theology, and oratory. The Sunni schools were more inclined to the study of law and theology and the Shi'ite ones to the study of sciences of nature and mathematics.

Note



The atmosphere of a *madrasa* has been the same throughout the Islamic world whatever the differences in the subject matter taught in Sunni and the Shiite schools.

The transmission of knowledge has always had a highly personal aspect where the student seeks a particular master rather than an institution. The relationship that exists between the teacher is a highly intimate one, that is one of reverence on the side of the student to the teacher; the student see the teacher as a kind of a father figure, who is to be obeyed even in personal matters not related with the formal studies. All religious education had been free; education atmosphere is characterised by relaxation and no academic or financial pressure was exerted on the student, it was always informal.

Bait al-Hikma - House of Wisdom

The first important centre concerned with philosophy was the Bait al-Hikma that was constructed in Baghdad by the Abbasid Caliph al-Mamun in around 815 CE (see lesson 5.3). It became the meeting place for scientists and scholars especially translators who translated Greek scientific and philosophical works into Arabic. Until the 10th century CE the main institution of learning a part from the *maktab* was the *majlis* - the circle or gathering of the learned that was presided over by a professor - *sheikh/hakim* or *ustadh* - where various sciences both religious and philosophical were discussed.

In 1005 CE, the Fatimid caliph al-Hakim built the *Dar al- 'ilm* or the House of Knowledge in Cairo. Here, Mathematics and Physics were taught. It had a library, and it became a model to be followed in other cities in later centuries.

Observatories

The construction of observatories as distinct institutions, in which observation is carried out and as centres of learning astronomy and allied subjects, owes its origin to Islam. The first Islamic observatory was Shamisiyah built by al-Mamun in Baghdad in about 828 CE. It was headed by the famous astronomers Fadl ibn al-Naubakt and Muhammad ibn Musa al-Khwarazmi. Others were built by al-Battani at Raqqa and by Abdul al-Rahman al-Sufi in Shiraz; at Hamadan built by the Persian Prince Ala'al-Daulah for Avicenna around 1023 CE. The Seljuq ruler Malik Shah built a royal observatory in Toledo in the 11th century. Private observatories of such astronomers as Avempace were built at Maragha in 1261 CE. and they were supported by religious endowment. This observatory was a scientific institution in which nearly every branch of science was taught and where some of the most famous scientists of the medieval period were assembled.

The peak period of the observatory as a scientific institution was reached in the 15th century A.D. when Ulugh Beg, the grandson of Tamaerlane built his observatory at Samarkand that along with the

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observatory at Istanbul should be regarded as the link of transmission of this institution to the Western world.

Hospitals

The hospital was also an important institution of learning since most of the teaching of clinical medicine was done there. These were the practicals. The hospitals had libraries and schools designed for that purpose. The Umayyad caliph Abd al-Malik built the earliest hospital in Damascus in 707 A.D. The Abbasid caliphs also organised medical education so that students, after undergoing both theoretical and practical training wrote a treatise. Upon its acceptance, they received a permit or diploma from their Professor, permitting them to practice Medicine. They had also to take the Hippocratic oath.

Many great hospitals were either built by rulers or by private individuals throughout the Islamic world, e.g. the Mansuri hospital in Cairo, Nuri hospital in Damascus built in the 12th century A.D. is one of the largest hospitals ever to be built in the Islamic world.

The Hospital served as an institution of learning as well as an auxiliary of the mosque schools in which the theoretical principles of natural philosophy and its branches including Medicine were taught.

Sufi Centres

In the early years the Sufi centres served as the meeting place of the sufis where they performed their various spiritual exercises especially the invocation, and where those who were ready, were able to receive initiation into the divine mysteries. They also served as centres of learning, but a learning which was not to be found in books and for the discovery of which it was not sufficient to train the mental faculties there. They served as centres in which the qualified could realise the highest form of knowledge, the attainment of which requires purification of the soul as well as the mind.

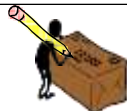
After the Mongol invasion, the Sufi centres became an outwardly institutions of learning. This was because of the destruction of the external institutions of society. In addition, to the esoteric sciences and gnosis, the branches of arts and sciences that had previously been taught in the mosque schools now found a refuge.

8.3.4 Summary



In this lesson we have identified and discussed some institutions of early Islamic education. These were: the Bait al-Hikma, the madrasa, observatories, hospitals and sufi centres. Some of these institutions such as the madrasa and the kuttab still operate as institutions of Muslim (Islamic) education. All these institutions had an important role in transmitting Islamic education.

8.3.5 Activities



- Identify the various institutions that have been used over the ages in the dissemination of Islamic education.
- What role did these institutions play in the development of Islamic scholarship?

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8.3.6 Further Reading



Nasr, S.H. 1968. **Science and Civilization in Islam**. Havard University Press, Massachusetts, pp.64-65, 70-90

Tibawi, A.L. 1972. **Islamic Education**: Its Traditions and Development into Arab National Systems, pp. 212-227

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LECTURE 9. Developments in Various Sciences and the Muslim Contribution

Lesson 9.1 Astronomy

9.1.1 Introduction

Having looked at the institutions of early Islamic education, let us now examine the developments of various sciences and assess the Muslim contribution.

9.1.2 Objectives



- To examine the major developments in astronomy.
- To assess the Muslim (Islamic) contribution to astronomy.

9.1.3 Content

In astronomy, Muslims continued the tradition of Ptolemy, and also made extensive use of the knowledge of the Persians and Indians. The first astronomers in Islam who flourished during the second half of the eighth century (CE) in Baghdad based their astronomical works essentially on the Persian and Indian astronomical tables.

The first official astronomer of the Abbasids was Muhammad al-Fazari. This was the period when direct Indian influence became dominant. Al-Fazari composed several astronomical poems and was the first Muslim to make an astrolabe that later became the characteristic instrument of Islamic astronomy. His major work that became known as the **Great Siddhanta** remained the sole basis of astronomical science until the time of al-Mamun in the 9th century CE. Yaqub ibn Tariq was also instrumental in introducing Indian astronomy into Islam. He studied under an Indian master and became well versed in the subject. It is actually through the efforts of these two men that Indian astronomy and mathematics entered the stream of Islamic science.

Sanskrit works especially Siddhanta of Aryabhata also became disseminated into Islam together with the Persian works of Zij-i Shah. These two became the source of astronomy until the time of al-Mamun when Greek works were rendered into Arabic. During the reign of al-Mamun, Greek astronomical texts replaced Indian and Persian works. The **Almagest** and the **Tetrabiblos** and astronomical tables of Ptolemy - **Canones Procheiroi** - were translated several times. Syriac translations also came into the scene and together with the Greek, gave the background to the rise of Islamic astronomy.

The early part of the 9th century CE, were dominated by Habash al-Hasib who directed the compilation of Mamunic tables. Others in the scene during this time were al-Khwarazmi who besides his mathematical writings, he left behind a wealth of astronomical tables. Abu Mashar, his work **Great Introduction to Astrology** was translated and printed several times in Latin.

In the second half of the 9th century, there appeared such figures as Thabit ibn Qurrah upheld the theory of the oscillatory motion of the equinoxes; he added a 9th sphere to the eight of Ptolemaic astronomy, a feature adopted by most of the later Muslim astronomers. His contemporary, some as the greatest Muslim astronomer considers al-Battani. He made some of the most accurate observations in the annals of Islamic astronomy. He discovered the increase of the sun's apogee (position in the orbit of the moon or any planet when it is at the greatest distance from the earth) since the time of Ptolemy, which led to the discovery of

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the solar apses. He also discovered a new method for determining the time of the vision of the new moon and made a detailed study of the solar and lunar eclipses. Al-Battani's major astronomical works that contain a set of tables became the basic works of astronomy in the West down to the Renaissance.

In the 10th century, astronomical observations continued with such personalities as:

- (a) Abu Sahl al-Kuhi and Abd al-Rahman al-Sufi. The latter is well for his figures of stars regarded by G. Sarton - a historian of Islamic science - as one of the three greatest masterpieces of observational astronomy in Islam
- (b) Abu Said al-Sijzi is noted for constructing an astrolabe based on the motion of the earth around the sun.

The 11th century marks the apogee of activity in Islamic sciences with such astronomers as:

- (a) al-Biruni - determination of the latitudes and longitudes, geodetic measurements and major astronomical calculations.
- (b) Ibn-Yunus - astronomer at the Fatimid court in Cairo. He compiled the Zij (the Hakimite tables) thus making an enduring contribution to Islamic astronomy.

The several new features of Islamic astronomy include besides all the refinements made in the Ptolemaic system, the star catalogue of Ulugh Beg, which was the first new catalogue since the time of Ptolemy and the replacement of the calculus of chords by the calculus of Sines and Trigonometry.

1) Muslim astronomers also abolished the eight spheres that Ptolemy had hypothesised to communicate the diurnal movement to each of the heavens; they substituted a single starless heaven at the confines of the heaven, above the heavens of the fixed stars which in undergoing diurnal motion carried all the heavens with it.

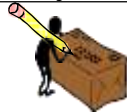
2) The second modification involved a change of the heavens. Muslim astronomers generally interested themselves with the nature of the heavenly bodies, planetary motion and the distance and size of the mathematical models with which they worked; they were also interested in descriptive astronomy as seen in the new star catalogues and fresh observations of the heavens.

9.1.4 Summary



This lesson has examined the various developments in, and assessed the Muslim (Islamic contribution) to astronomy.

9.1.5 Activity



Assess the Muslim contribution to astronomy.

9.1.6 Further Reading



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Lesson 9.2 Mathematics

9.2.1 Introduction

In our previous lesson, we looked at the developments in astronomy and assessed the Islamic contribution to astronomy. Let us now focus our attention on mathematics and attempt to see the factors that motivated the development of mathematics among Muslims and the contribution of Muslim to mathematics.

9.2.2 Objectives



- To discuss the factors that motivated the development of Muslim Mathematics.
- To examine the cultural traditions that shaped the development of Muslim Mathematics and the personalities that were associated with that development.
- To assess the Muslim contribution to Mathematics.

9.2.3 Content

The main elements of mathematics among medieval Muslims were Arithmetic, Geometry, Astronomy and Music. Mathematics was closely associated with astronomy and astrology. These two were cultivated because of various reasons.



Which were these reasons?

- Problems of chronology and calendar
- The need to find the direction of Mecca and time and day for daily prayers
- The task for drawing horoscopes for princes and rulers who always consulted astrologers.

The tradition of Muslim astronomy came from the Greek works of Ptolemy. Indian astronomy, algebra, geometry and related works were translated from Sanskrit into Arabic. Muslim algebra had its foundations in Indian mathematics that they synthesised with the Greek methods.

Algebra could be regarded as the most important science that medieval Muslims added to the corpus of ancient mathematics. In addition to this, the Muslims added the use of Indian numerals that are today regarded as Arabic numerals.

In Islam, traditions of Indian and Greek mathematics met and became unified into a structure in which algebra, geometry and arithmetic were to possess a contemplative spiritual and rational aspect.

The history of mathematics in Islam begins with the works of Muhammad ibn Musa al-Khwarazmi. The science of algebra could be said to have had its origin in the work of Khwarazmi entitled: **The Book of Summary in the Process of Calculation for Compulsion and Equation**. It is this work that for the first time, the Arabic word *al-jabr* (compulsion or restoration) was used. According to some scholars,

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this word gave the derivation of the English equivalent “Algebra”. Khwarazmi’s work was responsible for spreading the Indian system of numeration both in the Islamic world and in the west.

Another of the Muslim mathematicians who made a lasting impact was the Persian, Umar Khayyam. He was a master of mathematical sciences and his algebra is one of the most outstanding mathematical texts of the medieval period. This work deals with equations through the cubic order and classification.

Ibn Qurrah was another foremost Muslim mathematician who was responsible for calculating the volume of the cone (paraboloid). Al-Kashani was the greatest Muslim mathematician in number theory and computation. He discovered the decimal fractions and made a very exact determination of the value of the PI (II).



What were the achievements of Muslims in mathematics?

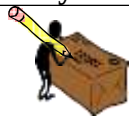
- The development of the number theory.
- Generalized the concept of number beyond what was known to the Greeks.
- Devised powerful new methods of numerical computation.
- Dealt with decimal fractions, numerical series and similar branches of mathematics connected with numbers
- Muslims developed and systematized the sciences of algebra and preserved its link with geometry.
- They continued the work of Greeks in plane and solid geometry
- They developed trigonometry, both plane and solid working out accurate tables for the functions and discovering many trigonometric relations.

9.2.4 Summary



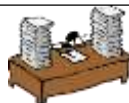
In this lesson we have examined the reasons that motivated the development of Muslim mathematics, the traditions that shaped that development, the personalities behind those developments. It is shown that Muslim mathematics were mainly a product of the Greek and Indian traditions. We have also outlined the achievements of Muslim scholars in mathematics.

9.2.5 Activity



Discuss the classical Islamic contribution to Mathematics.

9.2.6 Further Reading



Nasr, S.H. 1968. **Science and Civilization in Islam**, pp.140-157
Vernet, J. 1979. “Mathematics and Astronomy, Optics”, in Schacht, J. & C.E. Bosworth

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Lesson 9.3 Medicine

9.3.1 Introduction

A part from mathematics, the other branch of modern science where Muslims made a lasting impact is Medicine. This lesson discusses the development of Islamic medicine. It shows the major under currents that influenced that development, the personalities involved and the Muslim contributions to medicine.

9.3.2 Objectives



- To identify and discuss the cultural heritage that influenced the development of Islamic medicine.
- To identify the personalities that contributed to the development of Islamic medicine and the achievements of Muslims in medicine.

9.3.3 Content

Islamic medicine is one of the most famous and best-known aspects of Islamic civilization. It is one of the branches of science in which Muslims excelled. The School of Medicine was very significant because it was closely allied to other branches of sciences and especially with philosophy.

Note



The wise man (*hakim*) who was the central figure in the propagation and transmission of sciences was usually a physician. Hence, both sage and physician were called *hakim*.

Islamic medicine came into being as a result of the integration of the Hippocratic and Galenic traditions of Greek medicine with the theories and practices of the Persians and Indians within the general context of Islam.

Islamic medicine remained for the most part closely allied to alchemy (chemistry of the Middle Ages whose aim was to discover how to convert ordinary metals into gold). It retained its ties with numerical and astrological symbolism.

Medical texts of Greek, Pahlavi and Sanskrit were translated into Arabic and a technical vocabulary firmly established. Al-Tabari wrote the first work on Islamic medicine called **Paradise of Wisdom** that drew mainly on the teachings of Hippocrates and Galen among others. This work summarises the various branches of medicine and has discourse in the fields of pathology, pharmacology and diet. Rhazes, a student of Al-Tabari was known for his skills in prognosis (forecast of cause of disease) and analyses of the symptoms of a disease, its treatment, etc. He was also versed in anatomy in which he continued the traditions of Galen. In the West, Rhazes' most known work is his treatise on measles and small pox that was published in Europe many times, as late as 18th century. Rhazes was also a master of

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psychosomatic (mental, emotional) medicine and psychology. He treated the maladies of the soul along with those of the body. He never separated the two.

Avicenna on the other hand is credited for the first description of several drugs and diseases such as meningitis that he was the first to describe correctly. He was also known for the treatment of psychosomatic diseases or psychological treatment of physical ailments. Avicenna was the most influential of all Muslim physicians. For centuries, he held the title of “prince of physicians” in the West. He wrote large number of medical works and treatises on medicine. His masterpiece is the **Canon of Medicine**, the most widely read and influential work of Islamic medicine.

Muslim physicians also contributed greatly in the field of ophthalmology. The Islamic imprint in this area could be seen in such Arabic words as “retina” and “cataract”. The first important treatise on the eye was the: **Notebook of the Oculists** by Ali ibn Isa and **Selections on the Treatment of the eye** by an Egyptian physician called Canamusali.

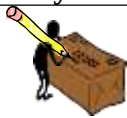
Ibn Nafis was the discoverer of the lesser or pulmonary circulation. He made a critical study of anatomical works of Galen and Avicenna that he published as the Epitome of the Canon. Abd al-Malik an Andalusian physician wrote the Book of Diets that ranks him as the greatest Andalusian physician in the clinical aspects of medicine. Ibn Tufail, a Spanish physician composed several medical works including a medical encyclopaedia entitled The Book Generalities on Medicine. In the field of anatomy, prominent scholars like Ahmad Ilyas authored, the first known illustrated work of anatomy.

9.3.4 Summary



The foregoing has demonstrated the Islamic contribution to medicine. It is shown that borrowing from other traditions, mainly the Greek tradition, developed Islamic medicine. The various personalities responsible for the development of Islamic medicine and their contributions is also discussed

9.3.5 Activity



Discuss the classical Muslim contribution to Medicine.

9.3.6 Further Reading



Nasr, S.H. 1968. **Science and Civilization in Islam**, pp. 188-219
Plessnar, M.1979. “The Natural Sciences and Medicine” in Schacht, J. & C.E. Bosworth (eds.) (2nd edition) 1979. **The Legacy of Islam**, pp. 425-460